



CITY: Pg 3

CM serves up 'Mayur'



NATION: Pg 5

SC slams Samay Raina, Ranveer Allahbadia



FILM: Pg 12

'If I keep repeating myself, I'll get bored'

TRUMP DROPS HORMUZ TOLL PLAN

US-Iran exchange fuels fears of full-scale war

US attacks Iran, Tehran retaliates across the Middle East, threatening shipping and oil prices

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: The US launched strikes on Iran early Tuesday, hours after President Donald Trump vowed to reinstate an American blockade of Iranian ports and charge ships for safe passage through the Strait of Hormuz. Iran responded with attacks on the Middle East allies of the US.

Later on Tuesday, however, Trump reversed his plan to levy a 20 per cent toll on cargo transiting the Strait of Hormuz, saying Gulf nations would instead boost investment and trade with the United States.

"Based on highly productive conversations with Middle East leadership, I have decided to replace the 20% United States Reimbursement Fee with Trade and Investment Deals that the various Gulf States will be making into the United States," Trump said on social media.

The president said the investments "will be MASSIVE" though it's unclear if these would be new commit-



TRUMP SAID GULF STATES WILL REPLACE TOLLS WITH MASSIVE US INVESTMENT AND TRADE DEALS

ments relative to what Trump announced after a visit last year to the Middle East.

The latest exchange of fire leaves in tatters an interim deal meant to pause the fighting, reopen a waterway that is key to world energy supplies and give negotiators time to hammer out a permanent end to the war. Instead, fighting has once again engulfed the region, threatened the global economy and brought warn-

ings to commercial airlines. Unless a diplomatic solution is found quickly, it could intensify into all-out war.

The focus of the conflict now is the strait, through which a fifth of all traded crude oil and natural gas passed in peacetime. Iran effectively shut the passage during the war by attacking and threatening ships — a tactic that proved its greatest strategic advantage. It sent the price of oil, fertilizer

and other goods soaring at a time when world leaders were already struggling to address rising costs.

The US has now threatened to reopen the strait by force — but experts say that will require a much bigger armada if not tens of thousands of American ground troops.

The US military's Central Command said it struck several areas in Iran, targeting "coastal defence systems, Continued on P4

KEY POINTS

» US threatened to reopen the strait by force if necessary

» Experts warned reopening the waterway could require a much larger US military deployment

» UAE-linked tankers Mombasa and Al Bahiyah caught fire after Iranian attacks

One Indian killed, 10 injured in attack on 2 ships; New Delhi summons Iranian diplomat

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: An Indian national was killed and 10 others were injured, including two seriously, in Iranian attacks on two oil tankers in the Strait of Hormuz on Tuesday, prompting New Delhi to summon the Iranian deputy envoy to lodge a strong protest and demand an immediate halt to such strikes.

New Delhi strongly condemned the attacks on the commercial vessels MT Al Bahiyah and MT Mombasa, which had a total of 30 Indian seafarers onboard, and reiterated its call for an immediate cessation of violence and a return to dialogue and diplomacy to bring peace and stability to West Asia.

The attacks on the two Emirati oil tankers came

amid escalating hostilities between the US and Iran. As many as 14 Indians have died in the West Asia conflict since it began following the US-Israeli attack on Iran on February 28.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said India is "deeply concerned" by the attacks on MT Al Bahiyah and MT Mombasa during their transit through the Strait of Hormuz and that both the vessels were carrying 30 Indian seafarers, among their combined crew of 46.

"Of the 12 Indian nationals onboard MT Al Bahiyah, one has tragically lost his life and another has been injured. Of the 18 Indian nationals onboard MT Mombasa, nine have sustained injuries, including two who are reported

Continued on P4

Passport regulates departure, not citizenship proof, says Centre

Less than 8% of Indians hold passports

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Tuesday said an Indian passport is issued by the government to regulate the departure of Indian citizens from the country under the Passports Act, 1967, while reiterating that it is a travel document and not proof of citizenship. The clarification comes amid an ongoing debate over whether passports can be accepted as proof of citizenship during the Election Commission's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls being carried out in several states.

Responding to questions at his weekly media briefing, MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said, "An Indian passport is a document that, as per the Passports Act, 1967, is issued by the Government of India to regulate the departure from India of citizens of India."

Jaiswal said passports are issued only after due verification carried out through an established process. He added that the issuance of passports



HIGHLIGHTS

» Government reiterates passport is a travel document

» Passport is not proof of citizenship, MEA says

» Clarification comes amid electoral roll revision debate

» Randhir Jaiswal cited the Passports Act, 1967

» Passports are issued after due verification, MEA says

» Passports are governed by the 1967 Act and 1980 Rules

is governed by the Passports Act, 1967, and the Passports Rules, 1980.

He also noted that less than 8 per cent of Indian citizens currently hold a passport.

The remarks come weeks after senior Continued on P4

J&K court seeks records in Rs 550 cr 'fake silver' offerings at Vaishno Devi

JAMMU: A Jammu court has directed the Jammu and Kashmir Crime Branch to produce the complete record relating to a complaint alleging large-scale irregularities in the handling of silver offerings at the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine. The Chief Judicial Magistrate (CJM), Jammu, has asked the inquiry officer to appear personally on July 29 with all relevant records and explain the action taken on the complaint, which seeks registration of an FIR into the alleged misappropriation, substitution, pilferage and adulteration of silver offerings valued at over Rs 550 crore.

The case stems from a complaint filed on May 9 by advocate Deepak Sharma, who alleged criminal conspiracy, cheating, criminal breach of trust, manipulation of official records and misappropriation of Continued on P4

BARS STRUCTURAL CHANGES

SC directs separate prayers space for Muslims adjacent to disputed Bhojshala Temple

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday ordered that Muslims be allowed to offer Friday namaz in a separate open space next to the disputed Bhojshala complex in Madhya Pradesh's Dhar district between 1 pm and 3 pm until the case is finally decided, while asking both Hindu and Muslim communities to remain patient because of the sensitive nature of the dispute.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana said the arrangement was temporary and would remain subject to the final outcome of the petitions. The court also directed the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) not to undertake any structural changes at the protected monument without its permission.

The apex court admitted appeals filed by the Muslim side against the Madhya Pradesh High Court's May 15 judgment, issued notices to the state government, the ASI and others, and indicated that it was willing to hear the matter on a day-to-day basis. The bench said it would list the case before an appropriate bench within 10 to 15 days.

"We have to be very careful about every expression used. These are very sensitive matters, and both sides must have patience," the Chief Justice observed, adding that the court had also taken note of the High Court order and the state's difficulty in maintaining law and order.

The Hindu community regards Bhojshala as a temple dedicated to Goddess Saraswati, while Muslims

WE HAVE TO BE VERY CAREFUL ABOUT EVERY EXPRESSION USED. THESE ARE VERY SENSITIVE MATTERS, AND BOTH SIDES MUST HAVE PATIENCE

identify the 11th century protected monument as the Kamal Maula Mosque.

Senior advocates Huzefa Ahmadi and Abhishek Singhvi, appearing for the Muslim side, argued that a long-standing arrangement allowing Hindus to worship on Tuesdays and Muslims to offer Friday namaz, in place since an ASI order of April 2003, should continue. They said the High Court ruling had disturbed a practice followed for centuries, with Singhvi claiming namaz had been offered there for at least 700 years.

Appearing for the Madhya Pradesh government, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta opposed restoring the earlier arrangement, saying doing so after two months would create administrative difficulties.

The High Court had declared the disputed complex to be a temple dedicated to Goddess Saraswati, set aside the 2003 ASI order permitting shared religious use, and said the Centre and ASI could decide its future management. It also suggested that the Muslim side could seek separate land in Dhar district for constructing a mosque. Hindu parties have filed caveats in the Supreme Court seeking a hearing before any order is passed on the appeals.

INVITES PUBLIC COMMENTS FOR 30 DAYS

Centre proposes nationwide ban on paraquat herbicide

AAISHA SABIR

NEW DELHI: The Union government has proposed a nationwide ban on paraquat dichloride, one of the world's most controversial herbicides, by issuing a draft notification that would prohibit its import, manufacture, sale, transport, distribution and use across India. Issued by the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare under Section 27 of the Insecticides Act, 1968, the draft order cites risks to human and animal health and opens a 30-day window for stakeholders to submit objections and suggestions before the ban is finalised. If implemented, India will join more than 70 countries that have either banned or



WHY IS IT DANGEROUS?

- » No antidote exists
- » Even small doses can be fatal
- » Damages lungs, kidneys, liver, skin and eyes

WHAT IS PARAQUAT?

- » A highly toxic weed killer
- » Used on 9 approved crops in India
- » Proposed for a nationwide ban

HOW POISONING HAPPENS

- » Accidental swallowing
- » Inhaling spray mist
- » Skin contact through cuts or wounds
- » Farmers and farm workers face the highest risk

phased out paraquat because of concerns over its toxicity.

The draft "Banning of Paraquat

Dichloride Order, 2026" was published in the Gazette of India on July 13. Continued on P4

WANGCHUK STAYS FIRM ON FAST, SEEKS DIALOGUE WITH CENTRE

Leaders urge Wangchuk to end hunger strike

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Activist Sonam Wangchuk's health has worsened after 17 days of an indefinite hunger strike, with fellow protesters saying he has lost 8.5 kg, is suffering muscle loss and remains in severe pain. Even as political leaders, actors and activists urged him to end his fast, Wangchuk has refused to do so, insisting that the government should instead agree to hold talks.

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), which has been protesting at Jantar Mantar for the past 25 days over alleged irregularities in the NEET examination, said Wangchuk remained determined despite his declining condition. The group also unveiled a five-point charter



Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk being attended by medical professionals P11

seeking sweeping reforms in India's examination system and announced plans to intensify its campaign with a "Chalo Sansad" march on July 20, the

opening day of the Monsoon Session of Parliament.

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke said Wangchuk's condition had become increasingly serious.

"He has started losing muscle mass and is in immense pain. Like everyone else, I begged him to end his fast. He calmly replied, 'Don't ask me to end my fast. Ask the government why they won't even have a dialogue,'" Dipke said in a post on X.

The organisation said several protesters participating in the hunger strike had also reported health problems. All India Students' Association activist Deepak, who was admitted to Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital after his condition deteriorated on Monday, was discharged on Tuesday morning. AISA said its other activists, Neha, Manish and Aameen, continued their indefinite fast from a separate stage at the protest site.

Continued on P4

India backs Palestine for UN membership

Reaffirms support for a two-state solution

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: India has reiterated its support for Palestine's bid for full membership of the United Nations and reaffirmed its backing for a two-state solution to the long-running Israel-Palestine conflict.

The position was presented by External Affairs Ministry Secretary Sripriya Ranganathan at the ministerial meeting of the Palestine Donor Group held in Brussels on Monday.

According to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), Ranganathan said India has remained a long-standing part-

TAKEAWAYS

» India called itself a long-standing partner of Palestinians

» India supports Israel and Palestine living peacefully within recognised borders

» New Delhi said its stance aligns with international law

and security within internationally recognised borders, in line with international law. She also reaffirmed New Delhi's support for Palestine's membership of the United Nations.

Ranganathan said India has continued to provide development assistance, capacity building programmes and humanitarian aid to Palestine. The MEA said India's projects are based on the needs identified by the Palestinian side and are largely focused on healthcare, education, vocational training and capacity building.

The ministry said India is currently Continued on P4

Indian-origin astronaut Anil Menon lifts off for first spaceflight

WASHINGTON: Indian-origin NASA astronaut Anil Menon and two Russian cosmonauts lifted off aboard the Soyuz MS-29 spacecraft from Kazakhstan on Tuesday, beginning an eight-month mission to the International Space Station (ISS). The Roscosmos spacecraft launched from the Baikonur Cosmodrome at 8:17 pm IST carrying Menon, Pyotr Dubrov and Anna Kikina.

The Soyuz spacecraft is scheduled to complete a two-orbit, three-hour journey before automatically docking with the ISS's Prichal module at 11:56 pm IST. The mission marks Menon's first journey to space, while Continued on P4



Expedition 75 Roscosmos cosmonaut Anna Kikina, top, NASA astronaut Anil Menon, middle, and Roscosmos cosmonaut Pyotr Dubrov, bottom, wave farewell prior to boarding the Soyuz MS-29 spacecraft for launch, on Tuesday AP/PTI

India calls PoJK unrest outcome of Pakistan's exploitation

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India on Tuesday said the continuing protests in Pakistan-occupied Jammu and Kashmir (PoJK) were the result of Pakistan's decades-long "systemic exploitation", denial of fundamental rights and administrative oppression in the region, even as fresh violence in Rawalakot left six civilians dead after Pakistani security forces opened fire during clashes with protesters.

Responding to questions at a media briefing, External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said New Delhi expected the international community to hold Pakistan "fully accountable" for what he called "egregious abuses and misdeeds" in PoJK.

"The ongoing protests in PoJK are a direct consequence of Pakistan's decades-long systemic exploitation, denial of fundamental rights, and administrative oppression in areas under its illegal and forcible occupation," Jaiswal said. He alleged that instead of addressing public grievances, Pakistani authorities had used "extreme police brutality", blocked food and medicine supplies, imposed internet shutdowns and used lethal force against unarmed civilians, including women and children.

The latest unrest erupted near Rawalakot's New Bus Terminal, where Continued on P4

— VICTIM WAS DECLARED BROUGHT DEAD AT BJRM HOSP; NO OTHER INJURIES —

Schoolgirl crushed under bus after collision with rickshaw; driver held

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 12-year-old schoolgirl was killed after a school bus collided with the e-rickshaw carrying her and other children near Majlis Park Metro Station in north-west Delhi on Tuesday morning, with a bystander alleging that several onlookers recorded videos of the aftermath instead of helping the critically injured child.

The deceased was identified as Priyanshi, a resident of Rama Garden in Mukundpur. She was on her way to school when the accident occurred at around 6.45 am.

According to police, a PCR call reporting the accident was received at Adarsh Nagar police station at around 7 am, following which a police team reached the spot near Majlis Park Metro Station and initiated rescue and legal proceedings.

A preliminary inquiry revealed that the school bus, driven by Kamal Singh (55),



collided with the e-rickshaw carrying schoolchildren. During the impact, Priyanshi fell from the e-rickshaw and came under the bus, sustaining grievous injuries.

She was rushed to Babu Jagjivan Ram Memorial (BJRM) Hospital in Jahangirpuri, where doctors declared her brought dead.

Police said no other child travelling in the e-rickshaw was injured.

The e-rickshaw was being driven by Ajay Prasad (45), a resident of Mukundpur. Police said the exact sequence of events leading to the collision is

being verified.

Govinda, who works at a nearby gym and claimed to be among the first people to assist the child, said he reached the spot within eight to 10 minutes while on his way to work and was shocked by what he witnessed.

"When I reached there, the girl was lying in a pool of blood. People were standing around, but many were busy making videos on their phones. I picked her up immediately and rushed her to the hospital," he claimed.

According to Govinda, the other children travelling

“When I reached there, the girl was lying in a pool of blood. People were standing around, but many were busy making videos on their phones”

in the e-rickshaw were crying and pleading for help.

"The children were requesting people with folded hands to save her, but many were only recording the scene. We took her to the hospital, but the doctors declared her dead," he alleged.

Priyanshi's family said she had boarded the e-rickshaw along with her elder sister shortly before the accident.

"We had safely seated both the girls in the battery rickshaw. Near Majlis Park, a bus hit it, causing the younger sister to fall onto the road. She then came under the bus tyres,"

family members said.

Another relative, Rakesh, said the family was informed of the incident through a phone call and later confronted the bus driver.

"When we questioned the bus driver, he admitted that a mistake had happened. There were many children inside the bus as well, while four children were travelling in the e-rickshaw," he claimed.

The family alleged that the school bus was being driven at high speed and in a reckless manner.

Senior police officers, along with the district crime team and the Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) team, inspected the accident site. The body has been preserved at the BJRM Hospital mortuary for post-mortem examination.

Police have seized both the school bus and the e-rickshaw. The bus driver has been apprehended and is being questioned, while the e-rickshaw driver has also been detained.

5 police teams hunt absconding constable accused of killing wife

CCTV footage captures the couple's final moments

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A day after a Delhi Police constable allegedly shot his wife dead on her birthday in east Delhi's Vinod Nagar area, investigators on Tuesday said five police teams are conducting raids across Delhi-NCR and Haryana to trace the accused, who remains absconding.

The accused, Manish Bhati, a 2022-batch Delhi Police constable posted with the Anti Auto Theft Squad (AATS), is suspected to have fled shortly after allegedly shooting his 30-year-old wife, Priyanka, in the chest with his service pistol following an argument.

The deceased's family has alleged that she had been subjected to dowry harassment since her marriage in 2023 and had earlier approached the women's cell with a complaint against her husband and his family.

Police said the allegations are being verified as part of the investigation.

A senior police officer said raids are being carried out in Noida, Greater Noida, Gha-



TAKEAWAYS

» The accused, Manish Bhati, a 2022-batch Delhi Police constable posted with the Anti Auto Theft Squad (AATS), is suspected to have fled shortly after shooting his wife

» 'The deceased's family has alleged that she had been subjected to dowry harassment since her marriage in 2023..'

abad and some places in Haryana. We have got important clues about his whereabouts. He will be arrested soon," the officer said.

Police said Bhati joined the AATS last year and was considered a sharp-minded officer by his colleagues.

According to the investigation, the couple left their New Vinod Nagar residence together on a two-wheeler in the early hours of Monday after an argument.

CCTV footage recovered by police allegedly shows them stopping on a road near Lal Bahadur Shastri Hospital, where an argument ensued before the constable allegedly opened fire and fled.

Priyanka, a teacher at a private school in Ashok Vihar, was taken to Lal Bahadur Shastri Hospital by a passerby, where doctors declared her brought dead.

A case of murder has been registered, and investigators are examining CCTV footage, electronic evidence and witness statements to establish the sequence of events leading to the killing.

Delhiites submit 'Heat Registries' to NHRC, seek rights-based response to extreme heat

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: A group of Delhi residents has submitted a formal representation to the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC), along with citizen-documented "Heat Registries", presenting first-hand testimonies and evidence on how extreme heat is affecting people's health, livelihoods, income and dignity across the city.

The submission, made under the Delhi Rising campaign, urges the Commission to take the Heat Registries on record as evidence of human rights violations, formally recognise extreme heat as a human rights issue, and recommend dedicated funding for Heat Action Plans by the Government of the National Capital Territory of Delhi, heat-vulnerable states and the Union government. It also calls for the implementation of the Six-



Weekly citizen diaries document income loss, illness, sleepless nights and other impacts

teenth Finance Commission's recommendation to notify heatwaves as a nationally recognised disaster.

"Extreme heat doesn't only affect the health of informal workers. For street vendors, the most significant loss is their work itself: there is less footfall during extreme-heat days, which leads to a loss of income and livelihood. There are no social security schemes that can compensate informal workers like street vendors for those losses or protect their livelihood. Extreme heat is

taking away both their earnings and their dignity, and there is no system to protect them," said Mohit Valecha, National Coordinator of the Indian Hawkers Alliance.

Describing the submission as evidence of a wider rights issue, Aakiz Farooq, Senior Climate and Energy Campaigner at Greenpeace India, said the Heat Registries document the impact of extreme heat on health, livelihoods, income, mobility, well-being and dignity.

Since May 2026, street ven-

dors, gig workers, residents of low- and middle-income neighbourhoods, elderly people, children, women and students have maintained weekly Heat Registries documenting their experiences of extreme heat, supported by medical bills, utility bills and records of income loss.

According to Greenpeace India, the handwritten diaries capture the everyday impacts of extreme heat that are often overlooked in official data, including sleepless nights, skipped meals, lost wages, children missing school, and heat-related fatigue and illness.

The submission cites Article 21 and key court rulings to frame extreme heat as a human rights issue, while Greenpeace India called for declaring heatwaves a national disaster and strengthening Heat Action Plans, including wage-loss compensation and improved public cooling measures.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Four minors who are feared to have drowned in the Yamuna in outernorth Delhi's Alipur area remained untraced on Tuesday, with rescue teams continuing an intensive search operation for the third consecutive day, police said.

No bodies have been recovered so far despite extensive searches by teams of the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), Delhi Fire Service, Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) and Delhi Police, an officer said.

Police suspect that the four boys were swept far downstream due to the strong current of the river, making the search operation more challenging.

Police said that teams in nearby districts and adjoining areas along the Yamuna river have been alerted and asked to



“Teams in nearby dists along Yamuna have been alerted and asked to remain vigilant in case the bodies are spotted”

remain vigilant in case the bodies are spotted downstream.

The four boys -- Rahul, Anshu, Saurabh and Aman-deep, all aged around 15 years and residents of Ibrahimpur -- went missing on Sunday evening while bathing in the

river near Hiranki village after they were allegedly caught in a strong current.

The search operation is continuing, and further action will be taken as per law once the missing boys are traced, police said.

Course diversity boosts Dyal Singh preferences

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Dyal Singh College has emerged among the most preferred colleges in the University of Delhi's undergraduate admission preference lists, primarily because of its higher seat intake and broad range of academic programmes rather than a shift in perceived academic standing.

Admission trends indicate that both the morning and evening shifts of Dyal Singh College together offer one of the largest seat capacities in the university.

The college also provides undergraduate programmes across multiple disciplines, making it a viable option for a wider pool of applicants. As a result, it appears in the preference lists of a significantly

larger number of students.

In contrast, premier institutions such as Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC) and St. Stephen's College have relatively limited seat capacities and offer a narrower range of courses. Consequently, they do not feature in the preference lists of every applicant, despite remaining among the most sought-after colleges for specific programmes.

A similar trend is visible in Sri Venkateswara College, which offers courses across the arts, commerce and science streams with a comparatively larger number of seats. The trend suggests that colleges with larger seat capacities and a wider range of courses attract more preferences, rather than reflecting any change in academic reputation or quality.

Goldy Brar-Lipin Nehra aides apprehended with 6 firearms

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Crime Branch has arrested two alleged members of the Goldy Brar-Lipin Nehra gang and recovered six sophisticated firearms and eight live cartridges, foiling an alleged conspiracy to supply illegal weapons for gang warfare and extortion-related crimes.

The accused, identified as Randeep alias Rinku (36) from Hjjajar and Hitesh Kumar (23) from Rewari, Haryana, were arrested following a tip-off received by the Crime Branch.

Police said the Anti-Gangster Squad received specific intelligence that gangster Lipin Nehra, allegedly operating from Canada, had instructed his associates through the encrypted Signal application to collect a consignment of ille-



“Investigators said Hitesh Kumar was previously arrested in a Rs 1 crore extortion case in Haryana's Pataudi”

gal firearms from Sardhana in Uttar Pradesh.

Acting on the input, a Crime

Branch team laid a trap near UER-II at Tajpur in Dwarka on July 7 and intercepted the duo while they were travelling in a Toyota Hilux. The accused allegedly attempted to flee but were overpowered.

During the search, police recovered one pistol and four live cartridges from each accused, besides four concealed pistols from a bag inside the vehicle.

Investigators said Hitesh was previously arrested in a Rs 1 crore extortion case in Haryana's Pataudi and allegedly supplied victim details to Lipin Nehra. Randeep is also allegedly involved in attempted murder and assault cases.

An FIR under the Arms Act has been registered, and further investigation is underway to trace the source of the weapons and dismantle the gang's arms supply network.

AIIMS outlines M.Sc. Nursing seat allocation

NEW DELHI: The All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) has issued the information brochure for the first and second rounds of online seat allocation for the M.Sc. Nursing August 2026 session.

Candidates listed in Result Notification No. 207/2026, dated June 27, are eligible to participate, subject to fulfilling the eligibility criteria prescribed in the prospectus and notices available on the AIIMS website. Eligible candidates can log in to the online seat allocation portal and submit an unlimited number of institute and subject/speciality preferences in their preferred order. Choices may be edited within the stipulated schedule and will automatically carry forward to the second round. Candidates who fail to exercise their choices in the first round will not be considered for either

round of seat allocation.

Candidates allotted seats in the first round must either accept the seat without participating further or accept it while opting for the second round. Those opting for upgradation must join any upgraded seat allotted in the second round, with the earlier seat standing vacated automatically.

Failure to join either the first-round or upgraded seat will attract a penalty of Rs 1 lakh. Candidates must report in person to the allotted institute within the prescribed schedule with original certificates or deposit Rs 1 lakh. AIIMS said reserved category and Persons with Benchmark Disabilities (PwBD) candidates must produce valid certificates during reporting. The second round of seat allocation will commence after completion of the first round.

MP/ST

— DTL OFFICIAL LOST RS 2.47L AFTER FRAUDSTERS DIVERTED CALLS AND BANKING OTPS —

Four held as police crack interstate mule account racket

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Cyber Cell of the Delhi Police has arrested four alleged members of an interstate mule bank account racket for their involvement in a Rs 2.47 lakh cyber fraud in which a Delhi Transco Limited (DTL) official was duped through a fake Blue Dart courier delivery call.

The accused have been identified as Arbaz Daniyal alias Labbu (20), Jimmy Bathla (41), Abdul Wadood (27) and

Aniket Verma (25). Police said none of them has any previous criminal record. They were arrested during coordinated raids in Uttarakhand and Uttar Pradesh.

An e-FIR was registered on June 16 under Section 318(4) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita after Satender, a resident of Babarpur and Deputy General Manager at Delhi Transco Limited, lodged a complaint.

According to police, the victim received a call from a fraudster posing as a Blue Dart



courier executive regarding the delivery of a parcel. During the conversation, he was persuaded to dial a number and activate call and SMS forwarding on

Using financial analysis, tech surveillance and field intelligence, cops identified beneficiary account holders and facilitators operating from Uttarakhand

his mobile phone. This enabled the fraudsters to divert incoming calls and banking one-time passwords (OTPs), allowing them to withdraw Rs 2.47 lakh

from his bank account.

Tracing the money trail, investigators found that Rs 80,000 had been transferred to a bank account belonging to Arbaz Daniyal, which was allegedly being used as a mule account to receive and channel proceeds of cyber fraud.

Using financial analysis, technical surveillance and field intelligence, police identified beneficiary account holders and facilitators operating from Kashipur in Uttarakhand and Mirzapur, Lucknow and Sul-

tanpur in Uttar Pradesh. Simultaneous raids led to the arrest of all four accused.

During interrogation, Arbaz allegedly disclosed that he had opened the bank account on Jimmy Bathla's instructions in exchange for Rs 50,000. Police alleged the accused sold mule bank accounts through Telegram to cyber fraudsters, exposing an interstate laundering network. Further investigation is underway to identify other members.



As part of Child Safety Awareness Month, the Special Police Unit for Women and Children (SPUWAC) and district police units organised self-defence training camps at several schools across Delhi on Monday. A total of 23,450 girls were trained in self-defence techniques during the camps

PLC/MP/ST

FOR COMMONWEALTH TT MEET

CM serves up ‘Mayur’



AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: With less than two weeks to go for the 22nd Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships, the Delhi government on Tuesday unveiled ‘Mayur’, the tournament’s official mascot, projecting the national capital as an emerging global sporting destination ahead of the seven-day international event beginning July 27.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta launched the mascot and the official championship trailer at an event held at The Lalit, New Delhi. Inspired by India’s national bird, the peacock, the mascot symbolises energy, enthusiasm and positivity, while its feathers incorporate the national flags of all participating countries. Highlighting the significance of the mascot, Gupta said, ‘Mayur is inspired by India’s national bird and embodies energy, enthusiasm, vibrancy and positivity. The peacock’s feathers beautifully incorporate the national flags of all participating countries, reflecting the spirit of Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam and the universal message of sportsmanship.’

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Chief Minister Rekha Gupta launched the mascot and the official championship trailer at an event held at The Lalit, New Delhi
- » Inspired by India’s national bird, the peacock, the mascot symbolises energy, enthusiasm and positivity, while its feathers incorporate the national flags of all participating countries

The championship will be held at Thyagaraj Stadium from July 27 to August 2 with top paddlers from more than 25 Commonwealth countries, including England, Australia, Singapore, Canada, Nigeria, New Zealand, South Africa and Malaysia, competing for honours. The finals are scheduled for August 2.

Expressing confidence in Delhi’s ability to host international events, the Chief Minister said the tournament reflects

the city’s modern sports infrastructure and organisational capabilities. She added that the government is committed to providing world-class facilities and greater international exposure to young athletes while positioning Delhi as India’s leading sporting capital.

Education and Sports Minister Ashish Sood said the unveiling of the mascot represents a broader vision for sports in the city. ‘The unveiling of the official mascot ‘Mayur’ is not merely the launch of a mascot, but the unveiling of a new vision for Delhi’s sporting future,’ he said. Sood added, ‘Our goal is not merely to organise sporting competitions but to build a strong, world-class sporting ecosystem.’ He announced that the Delhi government is developing five Centres of Excellence in disciplines including swimming, athletics, wrestling and table tennis to nurture future champions. The government said it is preparing Delhi to host more international sporting events in the coming years while creating world-class infrastructure and training facilities for athletes.

DDA sets 72-hour encroachment rule

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has issued an SOP for strict action against encroachment of its land and demolition of any unauthorised constructions within 72 hours, said a statement on Sunday.

The development comes after Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu’s instructions for ‘zero tolerance’ against encroachment anywhere in the capital, at a recently held meeting of DDA’s advisory council.

In line with Sandhu’s instructions, 14 flying squad teams have been formed under DDA zones to undertake systematic field inspections, technology-enabled monitoring and geo-tagged documentation across government lands.

The standard operating procedure (SOP) states that demolition of detected unauthorised construction and encroachment will be completed within 72 hours by four dedicated Quick Response Teams (QRT), said the DDA statement.

Ongoing unauthorised construction on private land falling within Development Areas shall be demolished after following due process of law, it said.

Under the instructions of the lieutenant governor, the SOP has been designed to facilitate early detection of unauthorised constructions and encroachments, enable prompt demolition and removal action in accordance with applicable legal provisions.

The teams will identify

unauthorised constructions and encroachments at an early stage, determine the ownership and status of the land, document violations through geo-tagged photographs with date and time stamps, and submit reports for immediate enforcement action.

‘Wherever required, demolition shall be carried out within 72 hours of detection by the flying squad,’ DDA said.

The QRTs’ responsibilities include carrying out the demolition of unauthorised construction and encroachments, submitting a demolition report along with geo-tagged before-and-after photographs of the demolition site by the end of the same day, it said.

The SOP further provides for the use of modern technologies, including drone-based inspections, wherever required.

The framework also integrates field verification with the Vacant Land Monitoring System (VLMS), enabling regular updating of land records, verification of vacant plots following demolition, and continuous monitoring to prevent re-encroachment.

There is significant emphasis on preventing recurrence of encroachments, in keeping with the lieutenant governor’s directive for sustained vigilance, the DDA said.

Following demolition and removal of unauthorised structures, the field teams will ensure continuous monitoring and protection of the land so that re-encroachment is effectively prevented, it added.

Several members of AAP, other parties have joined Cong: DPCC chief

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Devender Yadav on Tuesday said several workers from different political parties, mostly from the AAP, have joined the Congress in Delhi. The Delhi Pradesh Congress Committee president said the party’s organisation in the national capital is steadily expanding.

According to a statement, Yadav welcomed into the party fold workers from Patparganj, Burari and Adarsh Nagar of the Delhi Congress office. Those who joined included district, mandal and municipal-level office-bearers, besides hundreds of workers. Among those inducted were former MCD election candidate Mahesh Khari, former block president Joginder Khari, Anil Khari, Sangeeta Negi, Yogesh Shukla, Yash Bhatia, Shashi Mohan Kornala, Shaila Begum, Jitender Fulara, Rukmani, Renu, Shabir Ali, Sachin, Amit Chaudhary and Sanjeev Kumar, the party said.

Yadav said many of those who joined were from the Aam Aadmi Party. He said people were joining the Congress because they have faith in its ideology, principles and policies.

He credited the leadership of Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi for strengthening the organisation.

Delhi’s first child safety PTM on July 25

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a first-of-its-kind initiative, the Delhi government has dedicated the first Abhibhavak Shikshak Samvaad (Parent-Teacher Interaction) of the 2026-27 academic session exclusively to child safety and protection, making the issue the focus of discussions across schools in the national capital on July 25.

The initiative, announced by the Directorate of Education (DoE), marks the culmination of Child Safety Month, being observed throughout July in government, aided and private recognised schools. The city-wide exercise aims to strengthen

collaboration between parents and schools while raising awareness about child protection under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012. Education Minister Ashish Sood said, ‘A child’s safety is more important than any report card. Every child deserves to feel safe before they are expected to succeed.’

The Directorate has directed all government, government-aided, private recognised, MCD, NDMC and Delhi Cantonment Board schools to organise structured interactions with parents. Sessions will be held from 8.30 am to 12.30 pm in morning schools and 2 pm to 6 pm in evening schools.

“A child’s safety is more important than any report card. Every child deserves to feel safe before they are expected to succeed” — Education Minister

According to the circular, discussions will cover awareness about the POCSO Act, the role of Child Protection Committees in schools, body autonomy, safe and unsafe touch, personal

boundaries and the ‘No-Go-Tell’ principle. Parents will also be sensitised about cyber safety, online grooming, cyberbullying, complaint mechanisms, the Child Helpline (1098), and the legal obligation to report child safety concerns.

Teachers have also been instructed to discuss students’ emotional well-being, peer interactions, learning behaviour and academic progress with parents. Every class teacher will interact individually with parents for five to ten minutes and advise them on creating a supportive learning environment at home. Schools have been directed to maintain attendance records, document feedback and

ensure follow-up on concerns raised during the interaction. Heads of schools must also prepare a list of parents who fail to attend and subsequently contact them through phone calls, SMS or letters.

The Directorate has instructed district and zonal education officers to monitor implementation by visiting at least two schools under their jurisdiction. Government schools will also arrange tea and refreshments for parents using Parent Welfare Fund or School Management Committee funds. A consolidated attendance report from all districts will be submitted to the Directorate after the programme.

Old clothes, new purpose

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday launched the Old Clothes Donation Project, aimed at promoting textile recycling, reducing waste and creating livelihood opportunities for women. The initiative was launched after a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) was signed between the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC), the DMRC Ladies Welfare Organisation (DLWO), the Delhi Government’s State Urban Livelihood Mission (SULM), and textile recycling organisations Clothes Box Foundation and Respun.

Under the project, ‘Arpan Kendras’ will be set up at 10 major Delhi Metro stations, including Hauz Khas, Lajpat Nagar, Dwarka, Shahdara and Punjabi Bagh West. The centres, which will operate daily from 7 am to 7 pm, will collect old and unused clothes from citizens for recycling and upcycling.



Speaking at the launch, Gupta said the initiative would help reduce textile waste, promote a circular economy and encourage public participation in environmental conservation. She added that the project also aims to empower women by creating sustainable livelihood opportunities through Self-Help Groups (SHGs).

Collected clothes will be

sorted into different categories. Wearable garments will be upcycled into products such as bags and decorative items by SHGs, while unusable textiles will be recycled into yarn, fabric and other raw materials. Sacred cloth used in religious rituals will also be recycled respectfully.

Women associated with SULM’s SHGs will manage the Arpan Kendras after receiving specialised training in textile recycling and upcycling. DMRC will provide the infrastructure, while Clothes Box Foundation and Respun will handle segregation, recycling and technical support.

Citizens can donate clothes by scanning a QR code at the kiosks, filling in a digital form and receiving an instant digital certificate. The donation system will be digitally tracked through a central dashboard to ensure transparency and monitor participation. The government plans to expand the initiative across Delhi in the coming months.

DDA clears 10K MT of silt from Rohini

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA), under the directions of Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu, has undertaken a specialised desilting drive of the major underground trunk outfall drain in Rohini to restore the carrying capacity of the drainage network ahead of the peak monsoon season.

As part of the exercise, more than 10,000 MT of accumulated silt and waste has been removed from the underground drain. According to the DDA, years of continuous wastewater flow and heavy silt deposition had severely choked the pipelines, reducing their carrying capacity.

Since conventional desilting methods were ineffective in the confined underground pipelines, the authority deployed high capacity Super Sucker and Jetting Machines. High-pressure water jetting was used to loosen compacted silt, which was then

removed using powerful vacuum suction equipment.

The desilting operation covers a 4.095-km long trunk drain comprising three to five parallel RCC pipelines of 2,200 mm diameter, with a total underground pipeline length of about 16.50 km and 75 inspection chambers. The drain carries storm water and discharge from Rohini Sectors 20, 21, 22 and 23, along with parts of Kirari and Begumpur. The project is aimed at ensuring smooth storm water flow and significantly reducing the risk of waterlogging in Rohini and adjoining areas.

The DDA said desilting of storm water drains has been successfully completed in the East, South and North Zones, while work in the Narela, Rohini and Dwarka Zones is in the final stages of completion. To facilitate execution, Delhi was divided into six operational zones for focused planning, supervision and timely implementation.

MCD rolls out EduLife 2.0 for schools

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Tuesday launched EduLife 2.0, a digital portal aimed at strengthening academic planning, monitoring student progress and improving transparency in the functioning of its schools. The civic body also released Achievement Chronicle, a book documenting the achievements of its Education Department.

The portal was inaugurated by Delhi Mayor Praveesh Wahi at the Satya Narayan Bansal Auditorium in the Civic Centre. Deputy Mayor Monica Pant, Standing Committee Chairperson Satya Sharma, Leader of the House Jay Bhagwan Yadav, Education Committee Chair-

person Yogesh Verma, Vice-Chairperson Amit Kharkhari, MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar, Additional Commissioner Sanjeev Kumar Mittal, Director of Education Nikhil Tiwari and senior officials attended the event.

Describing the initiative as a step towards technology-enabled governance, Wahi said the portal would help integrate parents into the teaching-learning process while making school administration more efficient and transparent. He added that the initiative aligns with the objectives of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and supports the Digital India mission by promoting technology-driven education in MCD schools.

Leader of the House Jay



Bhagwan Yadav urged teachers to adopt the new platform wholeheartedly, saying digital tools would assist in assessing students’ academic progress and contribute to their overall development.

Education Committee Chairperson Yogesh Verma

said the portal would enable parents to monitor students’ academic performance, the distribution of mid-day meals and other school-related services. He added that a list of meritorious students studying in MCD schools would also be uploaded on the

platform, allowing sports academies and other institutions to identify and support talented students.

Officials said EduLife 2.0 is expected to enhance accountability, improve service delivery and accelerate the digital transformation of MCD schools.

2 Ggm police personnel killed in road accident

GURUGRAM: Two police personnel in Gurugram were killed on the spot in a road accident near Kheda Khurampur in the Farrukhnagar area, police said on Tuesday.

A speeding water tanker collided with a police emergency response vehicle (ERV) on Monday night, resulting in the immediate deaths of both officers and leaving another critically injured, they added.

The impact was so severe that the police vehicle was completely wrecked.

The deceased have been identified as Head Constable

Chhotelal and Head Constable Anil. Their colleague, Constable Dharmendra, who was driving the ERV, sustained critical injuries and is currently receiving treatment at a hospital.

According to the police, Head Constables Chhotelal and Anil, deployed on ERV-254, were out on patrol when a tanker approaching from the opposite direction collided with their vehicle at around 11.50 pm.

The impact completely wrecked the ERV and left both head constables and the driver critically injured.

Delhi demolishes illegal shrine on road

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Tuesday demolished an unauthorised shrine that had come up on government land in the middle of a road, removing a major obstruction to an ongoing road-widening project linking Pitampura and Shalimar Bagh. The action, carried out as part of the government’s anti-encroachment campaign, is expected to accelerate work on the project and improve traffic movement along one of north-west Delhi’s busy stretches.

According to the Chief Minister’s Office (CMO), the structure had occupied public land and was hindering the expansion of the road, which is being widened to ease congestion and provide smoother connectivity between the two residential areas. Officials said the removal of the encroachment would enable construction work to proceed without further delays.

The government maintained that it has adopted a zero-tolerance approach towards illegal occupation of public land, irrespective of the nature of the structure. It said encroachments on roads and government property not only delay infrastructure projects but also inconvenience thousands of daily commuters.

The demolition is part of

a broader drive launched by the Delhi government against unauthorised construction and encroachments that obstruct public infrastructure and compromise planned urban development. Authorities have intensified inspections and enforcement across the capital in recent weeks, targeting buildings that violate sanctioned plans as well as structures that fail to meet fire safety requirements. Official data released by the government shows that since June 1, authorities have demolished 94 illegally constructed buildings and sealed another 114 properties for violations related to building byelaws and fire safety norms. The enforcement campaign gained momentum following the June 3 fire incident in Malviya Nagar, after which stricter action was initiated across multiple districts.

Since that incident, 63 illegal buildings have been demolished. The largest demolition exercise took place on June 3, when 22 unauthorised structures were razed in a single day. Authorities also carried out extensive sealing operations, with 97 buildings sealed after June 3, including 79 properties on June 7 alone.

Officials said inspection teams from the Revenue Department surveyed 124 locations spread across Delhi’s 13 districts. Action was

initiated wherever violations were identified, with multiple agencies, including the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) and other departments, working together to carry out demolition, sealing and inspection drives. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has repeatedly stated that the government will act firmly against illegal construction, encroachments and violations of fire safety norms while creating a long-term system to curb such practices. The government is also examining the possibility of introducing a third-party insurance framework for buildings and public-use establishments. Under the proposed system, insurance coverage could be linked to compliance with structural and fire safety standards, encouraging property owners to adhere to regulations.

Meanwhile, the DDA has strengthened its own enforcement mechanism by directing officials to identify buildings with major deviations from approved plans. It has warned that architects responsible for serious violations could face blacklisting, while Flying Squads and Quick Response Teams have been instructed to step up action in development zones and land-pooling areas to prevent fresh illegal construction.

DIGITISATION CROSSES 12%

Over 98% of Delhi voters receive SIR forms

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: More than 98 per cent of Delhi’s 1.45 crore electors have been provided enumeration forms under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, while digitisation of the completed forms stood at only 12 per cent, according to official data published on Tuesday. As per the status report, a total of 1,43,02,626 enumeration forms have been distributed, covering 98.57 per cent of the capital’s 1,45,10,298 electors.

The number of physical



forms processed into electronic format stood at 17,66,553, accounting for 12.17 per cent of the total electorate. The door-to-door enumeration drive began on June 30 and will continue till July 29. With the distribution of enumeration forms nearing completion, officials said the

focus will increasingly shift to collecting filled enumeration forms and digitising them.

According to the CEO’s data, North East Delhi recorded the highest number of forms distributed at 18,70,636, followed by East (15,92,065), South East (15,25,698), West (14,40,443)

and South (13,30,445).

In percentage terms, New Delhi achieved 100 per cent distribution, followed by North East (99.99 per cent), East (99.30 per cent), Central North (99.28 per cent) and South West (99.20 per cent). North West Delhi recorded the lowest distribution percentage at 94.36 per cent, followed by Outer North (97.19 per cent), South East (97.97 per cent), North (98.78 per cent) and Old Delhi (98.82 per cent).

In terms of digitisation, South West Delhi led with 2,34,403 forms, followed

by West (2,12,681), Outer North (2,10,213), North West (1,76,034) and North East (1,67,544). Percentage-wise, Outer North Delhi recorded the highest digitisation rate at 25.25 per cent, followed by South West (17.63 per cent), Central North (15.41 per cent), North (14.70 per cent) and West (14.61 per cent). East recorded the lowest digitisation rate at 7.25 per cent, followed by Old Delhi (7.22 per cent), South East (7.90 per cent), Central (8.66 per cent) and North East (8.96 per cent).

ON MONDAY, MORE THAN 9,600 PEOPLE WERE AFFECTED BY FLOODS

Assam flood situation worsens; toll rises to 4, over 37,000 people affected

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GUWAHATI: The flood situation in Assam worsened on Tuesday with the death toll rising to four and the number of affected people increasing nearly fourfold to over 37,000, according to an official bulletin.

The latest fatality was reported from the Chariduar revenue circle in Sonitpur district, the Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA) said.

The person was reported missing on Monday night, and his body was recovered on Tuesday.

Earlier, one person died in Charaideo and two others in Dhemaji district.

According to the bulletin, floodwaters have inundated six districts -- Sonitpur, Dibrugarh, Lakhimpur, Dhemaji, Jorhat and Sivasagar, affecting 12 revenue circles and 99 villages.



A woman leads her livestock to a safer place following flooding caused by the rising water level of the Brahmaputra river, in Morigaon district, Assam, Monday

A total of 37,032 people have been affected by the deluge, with Lakhimpur emerging as the worst-hit district where 35,696 people have been impacted.

On Monday, more than 9,600 people across six districts were affected by the floods.

The affected people are being provided relief materials through 20 distribution centres, the ASDMA said.

The State Disaster Response Force (SDRF) rescued 16 people from Sonitpur district during the past 24 hours.

Floodwaters have submerged 1,103.94 hectares of cropland, while two animals were washed away and another 16,139 animals, including poultry, have been affected, the bulletin said.

Highlights

- » According to the bulletin, floodwaters have inundated six districts -- Sonitpur, Dibrugarh, Lakhimpur, Dhemaji, Jorhat and Sivasagar, affecting 12 revenue circles and 99 villages
- » The State Disaster Response Force (SDRF) rescued 16 people from Sonitpur district during the past 24 hours

PLEA ON NIA ACT

SC grants four weeks to Centre to file response on plea

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday asked the Centre to file within four weeks its response on a petition challenging the validity of the National Investigation Agency Act, 2008.

Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati, appearing for the Centre, told a bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta that the government needed some time to file the counter affidavit.

Senior advocate Siddharth Dave, appearing for the petitioner, said that notice was issued on the plea on April 21.

The bench granted four weeks to the Centre to file the counter affidavit, and said the petitioner may file rejoinder, if any, within two weeks thereafter.

It said the plea would be listed for hearing after six weeks.

On April 21, the top court



sought responses from the Centre, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) and others seeking their responses on the plea.

The apex court had observed that questions raised before it were of vital importance.

The plea has sought the setting aside of the 2008 Act, claiming it was "violative" of Article 14 (equality before law) of the Constitution and beyond the legislative competence of the Centre.

The NIA was set up under the Act as a central

The NIA was set up under the Act as a central counter-terrorism law enforcement agency in the wake of the 26/11 Mumbai attacks

counter-terrorism law enforcement agency in the wake of the 26/11 Mumbai attacks.

The plea said that 'police' falls under the State List.

It also referred to Section 6 (5) of the Act, which deals with the investigation of scheduled offences and says if the Centre is of the opinion that a scheduled offence has been committed which is required to be investigated under this Act, it may suo motu direct the agency to probe it.

From Page 1

US-Iran

missile and drone sites and maritime capabilities." Iran acknowledged the strikes but provided no immediate casualty or damage assessments.

"These strikes will continue imposing a heavy cost on Iranian forces and degrade their ability to attack innocent civilians and commercial shipping in the Strait of Hormuz," the US military said.

Iran responded with attacks targeting Bahrain, Jordan and three tankers that travelled through the strait.

Two of the ships were associated with the United Arab Emirates and were set ablaze for a time. The Emirati Defence Ministry said the attack on the tankers Mombasa and Al Bahiyah killed one mariner and wounded eight others. The Emirates threatened to retaliate.

Dutch shipping firm Stolt Tankers said that one of its ships came under attack. The attack on the Stolt Magnesium off Oman sparked a fire in the engine room, but the company said all the mariners were safe.

Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard said the Mombasa and Al Bahiyah "ignored repeated warnings." Iran has targeted ships that use a route through the strait that passes near Oman outside of its territorial waters.

Hours after the US said it ended its campaign of strikes, the Iranian city of Bushehr on the Persian Gulf was hit in at least four locations, the state-run IRNA news agency reported.

Bahrain, home to the US Navy's 5th Fleet, sounded its missile alert sirens three times early Tuesday. Jordan's military said it intercepted four missiles from Iran. Jordan hosts US forces and has come under attack by Tehran in recent days.

The European Union Aviation Safety Agency warned airlines against operating in the airspace of Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar and the United Arab Emirates, as well as over the Gulf of Oman.

Under the interim deal, Iran agreed that passage through the strait would remain free of charge for 60 days — but the agreement left open what would happen after. Iran asserts it has the right to manage traffic through the strait and potentially charge fees. The US has disputed that.

Any attempt by the US or Iran to charge fees would violate global norms on freedom of navigation and raise tensions, likely causing further economic disruption far beyond the region.

The price of Brent crude oil, the international standard, rose to a one-month high of over \$87 in trading Tuesday, still well below the nearly \$120 reached at the height of the war but threatening to raise costs everywhere. Regional mediators are still trying to get the United States and Iran back to the negotiating table, according to two regional officials. The officials said Pakistan-led mediation was working around the clock to reactivate the ceasefire.

Meanwhile, Lebanese and Israeli delegations were expected to meet in Rome on Tuesday to continue US-mediated

negotiations.

Before the fighting around the strait intensified, Israel's war against Hezbollah in Lebanon repeatedly threatened to derail the interim deal. A truce now exists in Lebanon, but it remains unclear whether it will hold if the US and Iran return to full-scale war.

1 Indian killed

to be seriously injured," it said. "We strongly condemn these attacks and acts of violence targeting seafarers and disrupting free and safe navigation through international waterways like the Strait of Hormuz," it added in a statement.

The MEA also reiterated India's "deep concern on account of the resumption of attacks and escalation of hostilities in the West-Asian region and call for immediate cessation of violence and a return to dialogue and diplomacy in the interests of peace, security and stability in the region."

"In particular, the targeting of commercial shipping and civilian infrastructure in the region must cease in order that free and unimpeded navigation and commerce through international waterways in the region, in keeping with international law, can be restored at the earliest," it said.

The MEA extended its "deepest condolences" to the family of the deceased Indian national and wished speedy recovery to those injured.

It said the Indian missions in the United Arab Emirates (UAE) are closely monitoring the situation and are in touch with the authorities concerned in the Gulf nation to ensure all possible assistance to the affected Indian seafarers.

"The Deputy Chief of Mission of the Embassy of Iran in New Delhi was summoned this morning by the Ministry of External Affairs and a strong protest against these attacks was lodged with him," it said.

MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said at a media briefing that India's strong protest was conveyed to the Iranian diplomat and that these attacks must stop at the earliest.

"We are closely following the developments in West Asia. We continue to call for safe and unimpeded navigation and flow of commerce through the Strait of Hormuz. This is key for ensuring energy and economic security of people across the world," he said.

Passport regulates

MEA officials, speaking on Passport Seva Divas on June 24, described the passport as a travel document rather than a document that establishes citizenship. They had made the clarification while responding to questions on whether passports could be used as proof of citizenship for the Election Commission's SIR exercise.

According to the officials, passports are issued to facilitate international travel and identify the holder's nationality, but they are not intended to serve as proof of citizenship for the electoral roll revision.

The comments triggered criticism from opposition parties, including the Congress. The party questioned how a passport issued only to Indian citizens could be treated as something other than a reflection of the holder's citizenship. It also alleged that the government was laying the groundwork to arbitrarily deny citizenship rights to Indians with whom it disagreed.

On Tuesday, Jaiswal reiterated the government's position, saying passports are issued through a legally prescribed process under the existing law and rules.

Leaders urge Wangchuk

As concern over Wangchuk's health grew, leaders from across the political spectrum appealed to him to call off the fast while also urging the Centre to engage in discussions.

Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee spoke to Wangchuk over the phone, enquired about his health and conveyed her support for the movement demanding justice for students, Dipke said.

Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav appealed to Wangchuk through a post on X, describing his life as valuable to the country and the world because of his commitment to humanity, democracy and the environment. While requesting him to end the hunger strike, Yadav also criticised the BJP government, alleging it had failed to respond with sensitivity.

AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal also urged Wangchuk to end his fast, calling him "an asset of the country". Addressing a press conference, the former Delhi chief minister said there were other ways to continue the struggle.

Support also came from the film industry. Veteran actor Zeenat Aman appealed to the government to open a dialogue with Wangchuk, saying India should not become a society that watches one of its "greatest minds" being sacrificed. In a post on Instagram, she said peaceful protests deserved a peaceful response and urged the government to begin talks on an issue that concerned the country's future.

Actor Omi Vaidya, known for playing Chatur "Silencer" Ramalingam in 3 Idiots, released a video asking people to pay attention to Wangchuk's deteriorating health. Referring to the fact that Aamir Khan's character Phunsukh Wangdu in the film was inspired by Wangchuk, Vaidya said he did not want the activist to die. He added that regardless of differing opinions on the issues being raised, Wangchuk's life should not be lost.

Meanwhile, the CJP presented what it described as a five-point examination reform charter. Spokesperson Vaishnavi alleged that repeated examination paper leaks over the past decade had not resulted in a proper database of such incidents or meaningful accountability. She also claimed there had not been a single conviction under the Public Examinations Act.

The proposed reforms include replacing the existing law with a Public Examinations (Transparency, Accountability and Can-

didates' Rights) Act, dissolving the National Testing Agency and creating a statutory National Testing Commission. The charter also calls for mandatory Comptroller and Auditor General audits of examination agencies, an independent Examinations Ombudsman, a Students' Rights Charter and a National Aspirant Welfare Fund.

The CJP has been demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over alleged irregularities in the NEET examination. The organisation said preparations for the July 20 "Chalo Sansad" march had been stepped up, with spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka claiming that more than 1.3 lakh people had registered support through its missed call campaign.

The group also said it had reached out to leaders across party lines, including BJP president JP Nadra and Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi, inviting them to visit Jantar Mantar and stand in solidarity with students. According to CJP chief spokesperson Saurav Das, the invitations were sent on July 9 and 10 as part of the campaign against the alleged NEET paper leak.

UN membership

implementing several projects in Palestine related to healthcare, women's empowerment and institution building. During the meeting, Ranganathan also announced a new set of initiatives covering rehabilitation, health, education and vocational training, reaffirming India's continued development partnership with the Palestinian people.

India calls PoJK

security forces launched a crackdown that triggered clashes. Six civilians were killed, including Zahid Mughal, Zafar Mughal, Arsalan Akbar and Wajid Hayat, who died at the Matial Mira Bus Terminal. The violence has added to protests that began last month over rising living costs, alleged administrative neglect, political discrimination and reported atrocities against minorities.

A day earlier, nearly 100 members of the PoJK community, including women, children and community leaders, demonstrated outside the White House in Washington. They sought international attention to the humanitarian situation, called for the withdrawal of Pakistani forces from civilian areas, and claimed an internet blackout had cut off nearly four million people. Protesters also appealed for humanitarian assistance through the Line of Control via the Poonch and Doda sectors.

Economic and health indicators also reflect growing hardship. A 2025 study published in Nature found that more than 57 per cent of households face food insecurity despite about 66 per cent of residents depending on farming and livestock. Nearly 29 per cent of the population is undernourished, while food insecurity affects up to 90 per cent of households in mountainous areas. Pakistan's Voluntary National Review Report said 39 per cent of children under five suffer from stunted growth and the maternal mortality ratio stands at 104 deaths per 100,000

live births.

Anil Menon

it is the second spaceflight for Dubrov and Kikina, according to NASA.

Menon's family, including his wife and fellow astronaut Anna Wilhelm, as well as NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman, witnessed the launch from Baikunur. After arriving at the ISS, the trio will join NASA astronauts Jessica Meir, Jack Hathaway and Chris Williams, European Space Agency astronaut Sophie Adenot, and Roscosmos cosmonauts Sergey Kud-Sverchikov, Sergei Mikaev and Andrey Fedyayev. The crew is expected to remain aboard the station until April 2027.

Born in Minneapolis to an Indian father and a Ukrainian mother, the 49 year old Menon is an emergency medicine physician and a US Space Force colonel. His father, K P Shankaran Menon, is from Ottapalam in Kerala's Palakkad district. Before becoming an astronaut, he served with the US Air Force in Afghanistan, worked with the Himalayan Rescue Association caring for climbers on Mount Everest, and spent a year in India as a Rotary Ambassadorial Scholar supporting polio vaccination efforts.

NASA said Menon will carry out scientific research and technology demonstrations to support future human space exploration while benefiting life on Earth. His work will include studies on the effects of long duration spaceflight on the human body, including changes in blood flow, vein structure and blood composition in microgravity. He will also test systems to produce intravenous fluids using the station's potable water, continue research on manufacturing semiconductor crystals in space, and perform ultrasound investigations using augmented reality and artificial intelligence to reduce reliance on medical support from Earth during future deep space missions.

Earlier, Russia's Roscosmos rocketry agency said the Soyuz rocket would also carry drawings created by Indian school-children, winners of the "First Forever" competition marking the 65th anniversary of Yuri Gagarin's historic flight and celebrating India Russia cooperation in space exploration.

Centre proposes

Representations can be submitted within 30 days to the Joint Secretary (Plant Protection) at the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare in Krishi Bhawan, New Delhi.

Paraquat dichloride has long remained under scrutiny because of its severe health risks. Doctors consider it among the deadliest agricultural chemicals as there is no specific antidote for poisoning. Even small quantities can prove fatal. Once it enters the body, it can cause irreversible damage to the lungs, often leading to fibrosis that makes breathing difficult. It can also harm the kidneys, liver, skin and eyes, while treatment is largely limited to supportive care, resulting in a high mortality rate in poisoning cases.

Agricultural workers and farmers are considered particularly vulnerable. Poisoning can occur through accidental swallowing, inhalation of fine spray droplets or prolonged skin contact, especially through cuts or wounds.

Although paraquat was approved for use in only nine crops in India, including tea, potato, cotton, rubber, coffee, paddy, maize, wheat and grapes, reports of misuse have continued to surface. In states such as Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh, farmers allegedly sprayed the herbicide on standing moong crops shortly before harvest to dry them faster and reduce labour costs. Such off label use raised concerns that chemical residues could enter the food chain.

The government has treated this widespread misuse as one of the main reasons for proposing a complete nationwide prohibition.

The move follows recommendations made by a government appointed expert panel and the Registration Committee after repeated regulatory reviews of the herbicide. Earlier attempts to restrict paraquat were made by states including Kerala and Andhra Pradesh, but similar measures elsewhere faced legal and technical hurdles. Unlike those state specific actions, the proposed order will apply uniformly across the country.

Once the notification is finalised, all existing registration certificates for paraquat formulations will stand cancelled. Manufacturers, importers and dealers holding valid registrations will be required to surrender their certificates to the Registration Committee within three months. Failure to do so could invite legal and penal action. State governments have also been authorised to enforce the proposed ban through inspections and action against violators.

Paraquat has already been prohibited or phased out in more than 70 countries, including members of the European Union, the United Kingdom, Switzerland and China, because of concerns over human health and environmental safety.

The proposed ban may also lead to closer scrutiny of other pesticides that remain approved in India despite facing restrictions in several countries. Chemicals such as glyphosate, 2,4-D, dimethoate and acephate have drawn international attention over concerns ranging from cancer risks and neurological effects to reproductive harm and environmental damage.

While the fate of those pesticides will depend on separate scientific and regulatory assessments, the proposed prohibition of paraquat signals a fresh review of older approvals in light of emerging evidence, patterns of misuse and public health concerns. If the draft order is adopted after the consultation period, paraquat's legal use in India will come to an end nationwide.

Vaishno Devi

nearly 20 tonnes of silver offerings made by devotees.

According to the complaint, the Shrine Board had sent around 20 tonnes of silver to a government mint in May for melting and storage. During testing, only about 5 per cent of the metal was

reportedly found to be genuine silver, with the remaining material said to contain cadmium and iron. The estimated value of the offerings was said to have fallen from about Rs 550 crore to around Rs 30 crore after testing.

Questioning the findings, Sharma said it was difficult to believe that lakhs of devotees from across the country had unknowingly offered fake silver. He also raised concerns over the reported presence of cadmium, describing it as a highly toxic and tightly regulated metal.

After alleging that the Crime Branch failed to act on his complaint, Sharma approached the court in June. In its status report, the Crime Branch said the complaint had been forwarded to higher authorities for approval and further action.

Sharma has challenged that report, arguing the Crime Branch, as a notified police station, was legally required to register an FIR. He has also sought preservation of CCTV footage, records relating to the collection, storage, transportation, testing and melting of the silver, along with assay reports and electronic evidence.

Calling the issue "a matter of faith", Sharma said a thorough investigation was needed to determine whether genuine offerings were substituted or whether devotees had unknowingly purchased fake silver before making their offerings.

AGENCIES

Nashik: Four killed, one seriously injured in road accident

NASHIK: Four people were killed and one was seriously injured in a road accident in Nashik district of Maharashtra on Tuesday evening, police said.

The accident involving two trucks and a Maruti Eeco car registered in Gujarat took place at Savala Ghat near the Peth-Dindori border on Nashik-Peth Road, they said.

According to police, the ill-fated car was travelling towards Peth when a truck coming from behind hit it. The car was on its way to Silvassa from Saptashringi Garh on Nashik-Peth Road when the accident took place at around 4.30 pm.

The crash was so powerful that three passengers of the car lost their lives on the spot, while two others were injured. One of the injured later succumbed at a hospital, while another car occupant is in critical condition and receiving treatment at the medical facility, they said.

The deceased were yet to be identified.

As per preliminary reports, one of the trucks involved in the crash suffered a technical snag and the driver lost control of the vehicle. As a result, the truck hit the car with great force and the car then rammed into another truck which was travelling in front of it, police said.

The crash was so intense that the ill-fated car was completely mangled, they added.

A case was registered with the Peth police station and further investigations were on.

AGENCIES

‘WOULD HAVE ENABLED REAL-TIME MONITORING OF KNOWN CRIMINALS’

‘Police suggestion on AI cameras went unheeded before temple theft’

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: The investigation into the alleged theft of donations at the Ram Temple has revealed that police had repeatedly advised the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust to install AI-enabled surveillance cameras and strengthen security at vulnerable locations inside the temple complex. The recommendations, however, were allegedly ignored, a lapse that investigators believe weakened the security system before the multi-crore theft came to light.

According to sources associated with the investigation, police had also urged the trust to increase deployment of security personnel at several sensitive points identified within the temple premises. The suggestions were reportedly not accepted by trust office-bearers, including former general secretary Champat Rai and trustee



The temple complex is now likely to be equipped with advanced surveillance infrastructure

Anil Mishra.

The Ram Temple is among the country's most sensitive religious sites and is protected by a multi-layered security network comprising the CRPF, Uttar Pradesh Special Security Force, Provincial Armed Constabulary, local police and private security personnel. Around 2,500 security personnel are deployed at the complex, while an Anti-Terrorism Squad team also remains stationed there.

Sources said police had

identified certain locations that required enhanced surveillance and regular monitoring. Investigators claim these areas were not brought under stronger police supervision despite repeated recommendations. A senior police officer confirmed that these findings have emerged during the SIT and police investigation.

The probe has also highlighted another long-pending security gap. A proposal worth around Rs 60 crore to procure vehicle scanning equipment

Highlights

» Police had also urged the trust to increase deployment of security personnel at several sensitive points identified within the temple premises

» The probe has also highlighted another long-pending security gap. A proposal worth around Rs 60 crore to procure vehicle scanning equipment for the temple complex was prepared nearly six years ago

FILE

for the temple complex was prepared nearly six years ago. Since then, the proposal has remained caught in administrative procedures without receiving budgetary approval.

Officials said Ayodhya Police sent multiple reminders to the concerned authorities stressing the need for vehicle scanning because of the heavy movement of vehicles inside the temple complex. The equipment has still not been installed, raising concerns over security preparedness at one

of the country's most heavily guarded religious sites.

Investigators said the AI-based cameras recommended by the police would have enabled real-time monitoring of known criminals by matching their faces with police databases. Any listed offender entering the temple premises could have been automatically identified. The SIT has recommended a series of technology-driven security upgrades, including AI-enabled surveillance systems.

‘SBI staff should’ve been vigilant’: Ram temple trust treasurer refuses to quit

PUNE: Govind Dev Giri Maharaj, treasurer of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, on Tuesday conceded that there were lapses in supervision at the Ram temple in Ayodhya, but said he would not step down over the alleged theft of donations as he did not consider himself to be at fault personally.

Noting that those arrested in the case are all employees of the State Bank of India, he told reporters here that the bank officials should have checked their credentials and should have been more vigilant.

Asked about the quantum of the alleged theft, he said his personal estimate was that it could be around Rs 3 crore, but it should not be taken as the

Giri Maharaj said negligence on Rai's part contributed to the situation

official or authentic figure.

He was satisfied with the ongoing Special Investigation Team (SIT) probe as well as the Supreme Court's monitoring of the matter, he said.

Reports claiming that he had decided to quit were "malicious", Giri Maharaj said.

"I never said I will resign. I am a follower of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj and I am not one of those who run away. When the time demands that I should fight, it is not in our

dharma to quit the field," he said.

On the resignation of the trust's general secretary Champat Rai, Giri Maharaj said he had stepped down voluntarily.

"As per the constitution of the trust, once a resignation is tendered, it is deemed to have been accepted," he added.

Rejecting the suggestion that Rai was made a scapegoat, Giri Maharaj said negligence on Rai's part contributed to the situation, and he had realised it before resigning.

"As a treasurer, I also have responsibilities. My duty is to oversee the funds deposited in the trust's bank accounts. Five chartered accountants verify the accounts regularly," he said.

MPOST

Maha Cabinet nod to changes to farm loan waiver

MUMBAI: The Maharashtra Cabinet on Tuesday approved significant changes to the latest farm loan waiver scheme, removing key eligibility conditions, including the previous Rs 50,000 upper limit applicable for the beneficiaries of the 2019 waiver.

The cabinet also decided to fast-track the redevelopment of Maharashtra State Road Transport Corporation (MSRTC) land by exempting the projects from the state's public-private partnership (PPP) policy.

At a meeting chaired by Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, the cabinet approved amendments to the Purnayashlok Ahilyadevi Holkar Farmer Loan Waiver Scheme, 2026, removing the earlier Rs 50,000 cap applicable to around 13 lakh farmers who had benefited under the 2019 loan

'Uddhav losing political relevance'

MUMBAI: Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Tuesday dubbed Uddhav Thackeray a "frustrated person" whose political relevance has diminished, making light of the Ram Raksha recital protest announced by the Shiv Sena (UBT) president. He said staging an agitation without knowledge of Ram Raksha (a Sanskrit hymn of praise dedicated to Lord Ram) is not appropriate. "Uddhavji should first learn how to recite the Ram Raksha stotra. He should at least read two pages of Ram Raksha. If he is prepared, I am ready to recite the Ram Raksha along with him," the chief minister told reporters. He said Uddhav Thackeray is a "frustrated person whose political relevance has diminished". "Such statements stemmed from frustration," he said.

AGENCIES

waiver scheme.

The change will enable these farmers to avail loan waiver benefits of up to Rs 2 lakh under the new scheme, subject to its provisions, according to a release issued by the Chief Minister's Office.

The Cabinet also withdrew the condition requiring farmers to take fresh crop loans and repay them on time during 2026-27 to qualify for incentive benefits. The decision is expected to benefit about 23 lakh farmers.

Committee probing irregularities in temple offerings reaches Badrinath

GOPESHWAR: A committee investigating the alleged financial irregularities regarding offerings and donations at the Badrinath temple commenced its probe on Tuesday, a day after the arrest of a temple committee employee, sources said.

The three-member committee, headed by Garhwal Commissioner Anand Swaroop, inspected the temple premises, examined CCTV footage and held discussions with temple committee officials upon arrival in Badrinath, they said.

On July 8, under the directives of Uttarakhhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami, the committee was constituted to investigate

alleged irregularities in donations and offerings received at the temple and make recommendations to improve temple management systems.

Apart from Swaroop, the committee includes Sandeep Tiwari, Managing Director of the Garhwal Mandal Vikas Nigam (GMVN), and Jagat Singh Chauhan, Director (Finance) of the Medical and Health Department, as members. Earlier, Shri Badrinath-Kedarnath Temple Committee (BKTC) employee Pramod Nautiyal had been arrested in the case concerning alleged irregularities in offerings and donations at the Badrinath temple.

Before his suspension, Nau-

The overall scheme aims to provide assistance worth Rs 36,585 crore to around 56 lakh farmers, according to the chief minister's office.

In another major decision, the cabinet approved the implementation of the Centre-sponsored Urban Challenge Fund (UCF) in Maharashtra with suitable modifications in line with Central guidelines.

The programme aims to encourage urban local bodies to raise market-based finance, strengthen governance, build institutional capacity and develop sustainable urban infrastructure. The state will create a separate budget head for the scheme and provide its matching share. Priority sectors include water supply and sanitation, creative urban redevelopment and developing cities as growth hubs.

MPOST

K'taka to get India's first govt-driven AI University

BENGALURU: Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Tuesday announced that Karnataka will establish India's first government-driven Artificial Intelligence University, reaffirming the state's ambition to become a global leader in responsible AI innovation.

He also announced that the government will set up an AI Hub as an incubation centre for research and development in AI by startups, companies and others.

The chief minister made these announcements while inaugurating Google I/O Connect India 2026 here, which is being attended by technology leaders, innovators, entrepreneurs, developers, researchers and policymakers from across India and the world.

Shivakumar said the proposed university would play a pivotal role in building world-class AI talent, advancing research and strengthening collaboration between academia, industry and government.

He said Artificial Intelligence is the defining technological revolution of the present generation, comparable to the transformative impact of the steam engine, electricity, the internet and mobile technology.

"Bengaluru is not just India's technology capital but one of the world's most vibrant innovation ecosystems. Karnataka's vision is to build one of the world's leading centres for responsible Artificial Intelligence," the CM said.

MPOST

BJP has institutionalised corruption, says Akhilesh Yadav

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav launched a scathing attack on the BJP on Tuesday, alleging that it has institutionalised corruption in the name of religion and donations, and accusing it of misleading devotees.

He also said a true patriot will expose this "criminology" of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and boycott it socially and politically.

In a post on X, Yadav attacked the BJP on the Ram temple donation-theft issue, saying people should understand the "criminology" of the saffron party rather than what he termed the "chronology of offerings, donations and contributions". The former Uttar Pradesh chief minister alleged that the BJP and its associates first establish covert links with devotees across the world, emotionally exploit their religious belief and collect large sums in cash as well as precious metals and gemstones.

He further alleged that the donors are discouraged from seeking receipts on the pretext of verifying the quality of the donated metals, while large groups of people are mobilised to temples where further collections are made in the name of offerings and donations.

The SP chief also accused the BJP of printing fake receipts during religious occasions, manipulating trust management by placing loyalists in key positions and expanding what he described as a "network of corruption". He alleged that there were irregularities in counting donations, theft of "religious wealth", disappearance of CCTV footage and other evidence, and land transactions in which associates allegedly bought land cheaply before trusts repurchased it at inflated prices and distributed the profit among themselves.

According to him, the proceeds were allegedly used to establish unregistered expand political networks.

MPOST

Kejriwal writes to PM Modi, seeks meeting over E20 petrol backlash

NEW DELHI: AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal on Tuesday sought an appointment with Prime Minister Narendra Modi to discuss concerns over E20 petrol, demanding that consumers be given the option to choose between pure petrol and ethanol-blended fuel and that the price of E20 be reduced.

In his letter to the prime minister, Kejriwal said there was "a huge public outcry" over the use of E20 petrol in vehicles that are not compliant with the fuel standard.

The AAP leader said he wanted to personally explain the technical issues and the feedback received from people during his proposed meeting



with the prime minister.

He also sought an appointment to submit a petition containing people's testimonies on the issue. Kejriwal said his two key demands were that petrol stations should provide both pure petrol and E20 fuel options so that vehicle owners could make a choice and that the price of the blended fuel

should be reduced, considering the lower mileage concerns.

"If someone wants pure petrol, they should get that option, and those wanting E20 should also have that choice," he said.

Kejriwal also claimed in his letter that nearly 30 crore registered two-wheelers and four-wheelers manufactured before 2023 were not E20-compliant and said owner manuals of these vehicles generally advised the use of pure petrol or, in some cases, E10 petrol, but not E20. He alleged that owners of such vehicles were facing reduced fuel mileage, accelerated wear and tear and possible damage to engine and fuel-system components due to the lack of alternatives.

MPOST

Judge who ruled on Gyanvapi case gives back-to-back 13 death penalties in 3 months

The string of verdicts has triggered widespread discussion in legal and social circles

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Additional District and Sessions Judge Ravi Kumar Diwakar, who came into national focus for his rulings in the Gyanvapi Mosque dispute, has once again attracted attention after sentencing 13 convicts to death in six separate murder cases in Muzaffarnagar over a span of just three months.

Between April 6 and July 6 this year, Judge Diwakar delivered six judgments in murder cases, awarding capital punishment to 13 people. The string of verdicts has triggered widespread discussion in legal and social circles because of the unusually high number of death sentences pronounced by a single judge in such a short period.

Under Indian law, however, a death sentence can be carried out only after it is confirmed by the High Court. The convicts also have the right to challenge the verdicts before higher courts.



Key Points

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before higher courts

» The first of the six judgments came on April 6 in the murder case of advocate Sameer Saifi. The court sentenced Singol Alvi, Sonu alias Rizwan and Shalu alias Arbaaz to death

The first of the six judgments came on April 6 in the murder case of advocate Sameer Saifi. The court sentenced Singol Alvi, Sonu alias Rizwan and Shalu alias Arbaaz

to death. On April 28, the court awarded the death penalty to Mukesh and his three sons, Pradeep, Sandeep and Sonu, in the Shekhar murder case.

In another verdict on May

30, accused Rais was sentenced to death in the Rajesh Devi murder case.

On June 20, the court sentenced Ramkaran alias Sawan Giri and Geelu to death for the murder of Rajendra Saini.

The fifth judgment came on July 2, when Deepak was awarded capital punishment for the murder of Home Guard personnel Ratiram.

Most recently, on July 6, former village head Pramod Kumar and Sahdev alias Pappu were sentenced to death for the murder of farmer Rajbir Singh.

The Rajbir Singh case dates back to August 24, 2010, when the farmer was shot dead while working in his fields in Mandi village under Titawli police station limits in Muzaffarnagar. The murder was allegedly linked to political rivalry arising out of a village head election.

Rajbir's son Pradeep had lodged an FIR against unidentified persons. During the investigation, the names of Sahdev, Pramod Kumar, Amit and

Vipin Sharma surfaced. Amit and Vipin Sharma later died in separate police encounters during the pendency of the trial.

After nearly 16 years of legal proceedings, the fast-track court convicted Sahdev and former village head Pramod Kumar and sentenced them to death. The court also imposed a fine of Rs 1 lakh on each of the convicts before sending them to jail under police custody.

District Government Counsel Rajiv Sharma said the verdicts had reinforced the faith of victims' families in the justice system. He said stringent punishment in heinous crimes sends a strong message to society and creates a deterrent against serious offences.

Legal experts noted that every criminal case is decided independently on the basis of evidence, witness testimony and the provisions of law. They pointed out that all death sentences require confirmation by the High Court and that every convict has the constitutional right to appeal.

‘Self-styled youth icons’: SC slams Raina, Allahbadia

Imposes Rs 3 lakh cost on influencers for ‘misconduct’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

‘Let them suffer now. If this is not arrogance, then we have to change the Oxford dictionary also’

unconditional apology in their podcasts or shows for ridiculing persons with disabilities and rare genetic disorders.

"We have no reason to doubt that Samay Raina has taken the court for a ride. He is in brazen violation of statements/ undertakings given before this court.

"The misconduct is sought to be compounded by stating that a compliance affidavit was filed yesterday, however, no affidavit has been filed," the bench said.

The CJI remarked that they think sitting outside the country is beyond their jurisdiction.

"Let them suffer now. If this is not arrogance, then we have to change the Oxford dic-

tionary also," the CJI observed, adding, "In public life, the more you respect others, the more respect you earn. You don't humiliate people."

The top court was hearing a plea filed by Cure SMA India Foundation alleging that Raina made insensitive remarks over the high cost of treatment for SMA and also allegedly ridiculed a person with such a disability.

During the hearing, senior advocate Aparajita Singh, appearing for the organisation, told the court that Raina never contacted them to join any of his shows and the affidavit filed by them says they could not contact me.

"Now we find it distasteful to ask for his show. He has apparently done shows with the disabled in some physical locations and did shows.

"I don't know what kind of youth icon he is. People like Samay Raina are apparently youth icons. I shudder to think so," she said.

SEEKS DISMISSAL OF PLEAS

CBSE tells Top Court: Three-language policy phased, student-friendly

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre, the CBSE and the NCERT have strongly defended in the Supreme Court the implementation of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020's three-language framework, saying it is essential for promoting "multilingualism and national integration".

The Union Ministry of Education, the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) and the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT), in separate affidavits, have sought the dismissal of pleas filed against the three-language policy adopted in CBSE-affiliated schools across the country.

Meanwhile, a bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant on Tuesday sought responses from the Centre, the NCERT and the CBSE on two fresh pleas challenging the board's policy mandating the study of three languages, including two native Indian languages, for Class-9 students.

The ministry, in an affidavit, has said the three-language policy is essential for promoting multilingualism and national integration. Recommendations concerning language education and multilingual learning form part of the larger educational reforms contemplated under the NEP, it has said.

"National Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCFSE) 2023, in pursuance of NEP-2020, reiterates the implementation of the three-language formula and recommends that students



Highlights

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- » Meanwhile, a bench headed by CJI sought responses from Centre, NCERT and CBSE on two fresh pleas challenging the board's policy

study three languages during Grades VI to X, with at least two of such languages being native Indian languages," the ministry has said.

"The vision of the policy is to instil among the learners a deep-rooted pride in being Indian, not only in thought, but also in spirit, intellect and deeds, as well as to develop knowledge, skills, values and dispositions that support responsible commitment to human rights, sustainable development and living, and global well-being, thereby reflecting a truly global citizen," it has said.

The CBSE has said the lan-

guage policy has been introduced through a "planned, phased and systematic" process and does not force students to abandon foreign languages.

In an affidavit filed in response to a petition challenging the board's May 15 circular on the three-language scheme, the CBSE has said, "The formulation of curriculum, the Scheme of Studies, the choice and sequencing of languages, the pedagogy and the mode of assessment are quintessentially matters of academic policy falling within the domain of expert educational bodies, and the scope of judicial review in such matters is narrow...."

It has submitted that the petitioners' concerns have already been substantially addressed through guidelines issued on June 29 and a subsequent circular dated July 10, which provide transitional relaxations, exemptions and safeguards to ensure that no student is disadvantaged during implementation.

According to the affidavit, students currently in Class 10 (2026-27) will continue under the existing two-language system and will not be required to study a third language.

SOUTH CHINA SEA India backs 2016 international tribunal ruling

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India on Tuesday called for upholding the freedom of navigation, overflight and unimpeded commerce in the South China Sea, and backed a 2016 ruling by an international arbitral tribunal that rejected Beijing's extensive territorial claims over the resource-rich region.

New Delhi's remarks on the South China Sea dispute came two days after the US, the UK and a dozen other Western and Asian countries reminded China about the tribunal's verdict that its expansive claims in the region are illegal.

A joint statement was issued by the US, the UK and 12 other nations on July 12 commemorating the landmark verdict by the tribunal established in The Hague under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea.

China had rejected the ruling.



A view of South China Sea

ANI

"India's position on the South China Sea issue is well known. We emphasise the importance of upholding freedom of navigation and overflight, other lawful uses of the sea, and unimpeded commerce consistent with international law, as reflected in UNCLOS (UN Convention on the Law of the Sea)," External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said at a media briefing.

He was asked about the joint statement.

"We re-affirm that maritime disputes must be resolved

peacefully and in accordance with UNCLOS, and reiterate that the award rendered 10 years ago by the arbitral tribunal is a significant milestone and the basis for peacefully resolving disputes between the parties," he said.

There have been growing concerns over China's sweeping claims of sovereignty over all of the South China Sea, a huge source of hydrocarbons.

Several countries in the region including Vietnam, the Philippines and Brunei, have

counterclaims.

India has been pitching for a rules-based order in the region including through upholding adherence to international law, especially the UNCLOS.

Apart from the US and the UK, the other countries to sign the joint statement were: the Philippines, Japan, Australia, New Zealand, Canada, Germany, Italy, Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, Romania and Slovenia.

"We reiterate our strong opposition to any destabilising or unilateral actions including by force or coercion that threaten peace and stability in the region," they said.

The countries also underlined the importance of "freedom of navigation and overflight as well as other internationally lawful uses of the sea as reflected in UNCLOS".

They also called for resolution of the territorial disputes peacefully based on the 1982 UN convention on seas.

NFR: Redevelopment of 3 Railway Stations completed

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MALIGAON: Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR) has achieved another significant milestone in its journey towards modernisation as three stations under its jurisdiction i.e. Majbat in Rangiya Division, Jalpaiguri Road in Alipurduar Division and Haldibari in Katihar Division have been redeveloped under Amrit Bharat Station Scheme.

This marks a major step towards transforming railway stations into modern, accessible and passenger-friendly transport hubs while preserving the local heritage and cultural identity of each region.

These three stations, located across Assam & West



Bengal, have been comprehensively upgraded to provide enhanced passenger amenities and improved travel experience, in line with the Government of India's vision of developing world-class railway infrastructure across the railways.

Under the Amrit Bharat Station Scheme, Majbat railway station in Assam has been redeveloped at a cost of Rs 10.19 crore, Jalpaiguri Road railway station at Rs 34.80 crore and Haldibari railway station at approximately Rs 26 crore.

QAA audit reports: CM Saini directs departments to act on irregularities

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini said that there will be zero tolerance for poor-quality government construction works, directing all departments to ensure that every public infrastructure project is executed strictly in accordance with prescribed standards and specifications.

The concerned departments should pay particular attention to road layering and ensure strict compliance with the specifications laid down in the tender documents.

Strict action will be taken against the responsible officers and employees if any negligence, poor quality, or violation of rules are found in the construction work.

Saini was chairing a review

meeting of the Quality Assurance Authority (QAA) on Tuesday to assess the quality of government construction works and the progress of technical audits being conducted across various departments.

During the meeting, Chairman, QAA, Rajeev Arora presented an update on the implementation of decisions taken during the previous review meeting, the progress made by various departments and the future action plan.

He also presented technical audit reports on ongoing infrastructure projects across the state, supported by photographs and other technical evidence highlighting project planning, construction quality, compliance with prescribed standards and areas requiring improvement.

The meeting primarily reviewed projects undertaken by the Irrigation, Public Works, Power, and Public Health Engineering Departments.

The Chief Minister directed that, in addition to auditing construction projects executed by state government departments, the Quality Assurance Authority should also conduct periodic audits of construction works carried out by Central Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs) in Haryana.

Meanwhile, Haryana Chief Minister Saini has unveiled a comprehensive roadmap to transform the state's higher education system through research, innovation and emerging technologies, which will play a vital role in achieving the vision of Viksit Bharat and Viksit Haryana by 2047.

TO BOOST DIGITAL FORENSIC INFRA Centre announces five new Examiners of Electronic Evidence

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major boost to statutory digital forensic infrastructure, the Centre has announced five new Examiners of Electronic Evidence, including the elite Special Instruments Wing (SIW) of the Border Security Force (BSF), to strengthen the country's capacity to examine the growing volume of electronic evidence from digital crimes, officials said on Tuesday.

Sources said the SIW will handle a specialised arm of electronic evidence -- Drone Forensics.

The designation of SIW for drone forensic underscores

Sources said the SIW will handle a specialised arm of electronic evidence -- Drone Forensics

the increasing importance of drone-related evidence as security agencies confront the unmanned aerial systems for cross-border narcotics and arms smuggling, surveillance and other unlawful operations, the sources said.

The Directorate of Forensic Science Laboratories (DFS), Mumbai; the National Forensic Science University, Goa; and the Central Foren-

sic Science Laboratory, Kolkata, under the Directorate of Forensic Science Services of the Union Ministry of Home Affairs will handle and analyse evidence requiring Computer (Media) Forensics and Mobile Device Forensics.

The Jaipur-based Cyber Forensic Division, State Forensic Science Laboratory, will handle Computer (Media) Forensics, excluding Floppy Disk and Mobile Devices Forensics, they said.

The Centre has designated these laboratories as Examiners of Electronic Evidence under Section 79A of the Information Technology Act, they said.

SC clears woman of killing husband after 19 years

NEW DELHI: About nineteen years after a banker was found dead and police claimed his wife conspired with her alleged lover to murder him, the Supreme Court has exonerated the woman, ruling that suspicion, however grave, cannot replace the legal proof.

A bench of justices Sanjay Karol and Prasanna B Varale upheld the acquittal of Monika Kiran Suryawanshi, refusing to revive murder and conspiracy charges against her.

She was accused of killing her husband, Kiran Suryawanshi, who was a bank employee, in February 2007 over an alleged extramarital affair.

The top court said that the prosecution failed to establish an unbroken chain of circumstances necessary to secure a conviction in a case that was based entirely on circumstan-

Woman was accused of killing her husband in February 2007 over an alleged extramarital affair

tial evidence.

"The chain of circumstances is broken, and the hypothesis of guilt is not exclusively established," said the bench on Monday, while dismissing appeals filed by Maharashtra against the Bombay High Court's 2010 acquittal.

According to the prosecution, Monika, who had a love marriage with Kiran in 2001, was allegedly involved in an extramarital relationship with a neighbour.

AGENCIES

UNDER THE LEADERSHIP OF PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA MODI

Haryana emerges as a pioneer of India's modern railway revolution



In this journey of development, Haryana has achieved a historic milestone. The operation of the country's first hydrogen-powered train on the Jind-Sonapat railway section is a matter of pride not only for the State but for the entire nation. This project will further strengthen the resolve of Viksit Bharat and Green India.

Prime Minister Modi has always emphasised that India's development should be based on modern technology, innovation and self-reliance. As a result of this vision, India is today achieving new milestones through indigenous technology. The Jind-Sonapat Hydrogen Train Project is a transformative initiative in the history of Indian Railways. It demonstrates that India is no longer merely a consumer of technology but has emerged as a creator of new technologies and a nation capable of providing technological leadership to the world.

Developed with an entirely indigenous design, manufacturing, and conversion process, this train is a living example of the capability of Indian engineers and the resolve of

Atmanirbhar Bharat. It will be among the world's longest hydrogen-powered trains operating on broad gauge tracks. Built at a cost of approximately Rs 141 crore, the train will comprise two driving power cars and eight passenger coaches. With a power output of approximately 2,400 kilowatts, it will be among the most powerful hydrogen-powered trains of Indian Railways. The successful trial of the train has been completed, and approval from the Chief Commissioner of Railway Safety (CCRS) has also been obtained. This clearly reflects that India has taken a decisive step towards modern, safe and environmentally friendly rail transportation.

This achievement is of special significance for Haryana because the project will play an important role in establishing the State as a centre of modern railway technology. The train will operate on the approximately 89-kilometre Jind-Sonapat rail section, giving a new identity to the state's transport system. It will not only provide passengers with modern amenities but will also promote the use of clean

energy. In the coming years, such projects will make a significant contribution towards reducing carbon emissions and achieving global green development goals.

The development visible in Haryana today is the outcome of the coordinated efforts of the Central government and the state government. Under the leadership of PM Modi, the double engine government in Haryana have given a new momentum to the state's development. Whether it is the expansion of national highways, modernisation of railway infrastructure, expansion of air connectivity, promotion of industrial investment, new initiatives in health and education, or the development of modern public infrastructure, Haryana is continuously progressing in every sector. The Jind-Sonapat Hydrogen Train Project is another outstanding example of this coordinated development vision.

PM Modi has consistently maintained that the benefits of development should not remain confined to major cities alone but should reach every state and every region of the

country. In line with this vision, Haryana has witnessed unprecedented progress in railway infrastructure, roads, energy, industry and digital infrastructure. The rapid implementation of modern projects across the state reflects that the double engine government is giving the highest priority to public welfare while advancing development in accordance with future requirements.

Hydrogen energy is regarded as the clean energy of the future. Its use will not only promote environmental protection but will also help make India self-reliant in the energy sector. The adoption of hydrogen technology by Indian Railways is proof that the country is preparing today for the challenges of tomorrow. This initiative provides a strong foundation to Prime Minister's vision of 'Viksit Bharat' and 'Green India.'

Today, India is emerging before the world as a nation that is writing a new chapter of development by harmoniously blending tradition with modernity. Haryana is an active partner in this transformational journey. The Jind-Sonapat

Hydrogen Train Project will also open new avenues for the youth of the state, engineers and the industrial sector by creating fresh opportunities for employment and investment in advanced technologies.

I am fully confident that under the inspiring leadership of PM Modi, and through the joint efforts of the Central and Haryana government, the state will continue to set new milestones of development. The Jind-Sonapat Hydrogen Train Project is not merely a railway project; it is a powerful symbol of AtmanirbharBharat, Green Development, Modern Technology and the resolve of Viksit Bharat. It will lay a strong foundation for a clean, safe and modern India for future generations and further strengthen Haryana's position among the country's leading progressive States.

— Nayab Singh Saini
Haryana Chief Minister





EDITORIAL

A NEW CHAPTER

The implementation of the India–United Kingdom Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) on July 15 marks an important milestone in India’s evolving trade policy. It is not merely another free trade agreement but a reflection of New Delhi’s growing confidence in pursuing deeper economic integration with major global economies while safeguarding domestic interests. As the sixth such pact to come into force under the Narendra Modi government, following agreements with Mauritius, the UAE, Australia, EFTA and Oman, CETA signals a strategic shift towards using trade diplomacy as an instrument of economic growth. At a time when global commerce is being reshaped by geopolitical tensions, supply-chain disruptions and rising protectionism, the agreement demonstrates that India is willing to engage with international markets rather than retreat behind tariff walls. Its promise of duty-free access for nearly 99 per cent of Indian exports to the UK is significant, but tariff reductions alone do not guarantee prosperity. Every trade agreement succeeds or fails on how effectively businesses, governments and workers respond to the opportunities it creates. If industries remain uncompetitive or exporters fail to meet global standards, preferential market access will remain an underutilised privilege. CETA should therefore be viewed not as the end of negotiations but as the beginning of a new phase in India’s economic journey.

The sectors expected to benefit immediately explain why the agreement has generated considerable optimism. Labour-intensive industries such as garments, textiles, footwear, carpets, processed foods, seafood, spices, fruits and vegetables will now enter the British market without duties that previously ranged from four to sixteen per cent. These industries employ millions of Indians and are dominated by micro, small and medium enterprises that often struggle against global competition. Easier market access can encourage investment, expand production and generate employment across manufacturing clusters. The agreement also creates opportunities for machinery, electronics, fabricated metal products, ceramics and automobile components, complementing India’s ambition to become a global manufacturing hub. Consumers may also gain through gradual reductions in duties on selected British goods such as machinery, electronics, cosmetics, chocolates and premium food products. While much attention has focused on lower tariffs for Scotch whisky and other premium alcoholic beverages, these are relatively small elements of a much larger economic framework. The broader significance lies in creating predictable market access, encouraging investment and strengthening supply chains between two economies whose commercial relationship continues to deepen. Greater certainty often attracts long-term investment as effectively as fiscal incentives.

The automobile chapter has understandably attracted the closest scrutiny. India has traditionally protected its automobile industry through high import duties, making the decision to reduce tariffs on British-made vehicles particularly noteworthy. However, the agreement reflects careful sequencing rather than abrupt liberalisation. Tariffs on eligible British cars will fall gradually under specified quotas, while electric, hybrid and hydrogen-powered passenger vehicles will receive preferential access only from the sixth year. This effectively gives Indian electric vehicle manufacturers five years to strengthen their technological capabilities, improve efficiency and expand production before facing greater competition. Such calibrated opening balances consumer interests with industrial development. Equally important, Britain has granted preferential access to eligible Indian electric and hybrid vehicles within annual quotas, creating new export opportunities for Indian manufacturers. Competition should not be viewed solely as a threat. When introduced gradually, it encourages innovation, better quality and higher productivity. Indian manufacturers cannot rely indefinitely on protection if they aspire to become globally competitive. The agreement offers both a challenge and an opportunity to modernise, invest in research and move further up global value chains.

CETA’s importance extends well beyond merchandise trade. The Double Contribution Convention exempts Indian professionals temporarily working in Britain from social security contributions for up to five years, significantly benefiting India’s globally competitive information technology and consulting sectors. Companies with large overseas operations will gain from lower employment costs and easier workforce mobility. India also succeeded in protecting critical public-interest safeguards during negotiations on intellectual property rights by resisting patent-term extensions and pharmaceutical data exclusivity while preserving compulsory licensing provisions. At the same time, both countries retained protection for politically sensitive sectors. India excluded products such as fresh apples, walnuts, selected dairy products, smartphones and gold bars from tariff concessions, while Britain protected rice, sugar and certain meat products. These exclusions demonstrate that modern trade agreements are exercises in careful compromise rather than unrestricted liberalisation. The inclusion of strict rules of origin further ensures that third-country products cannot misuse the agreement through minimal processing merely to claim tariff benefits.

The agreement’s long-term success, however, will depend less on tariff schedules than on India’s ability to improve competitiveness. Exporters must still comply with demanding British quality standards, sustainability norms and regulatory requirements. Small and medium enterprises require better logistics, easier credit, modern infrastructure and stronger export support if they are to fully utilise preferential access. Emerging challenges, including Britain’s tighter steel safeguard regime and the growing importance of environmental standards in international trade, also remind policymakers that tariffs are only one component of competitiveness. Encouragingly, bilateral trade has already crossed USD 25 billion, while British investment in India continues to rise. CETA provides a stronger institutional framework to deepen this relationship further. But trade agreements open doors; they do not guarantee success. Whether July 15 is remembered simply as the date another free trade agreement came into force or as the beginning of a new chapter in India’s export-led growth story will ultimately depend on the country’s willingness to pursue reforms, strengthen manufacturing and equip its businesses to compete confidently in an increasingly demanding global marketplace.

BHARAT KI SOCH



ANIL RAJPUT

THE WRITER IS THE CHAIRPERSON, BHARAT KI SOCH

From families to corporate boardrooms, institutions weaken when favourites are protected, uncomfortable advice is ignored and those in authority choose personal loyalty over fairness

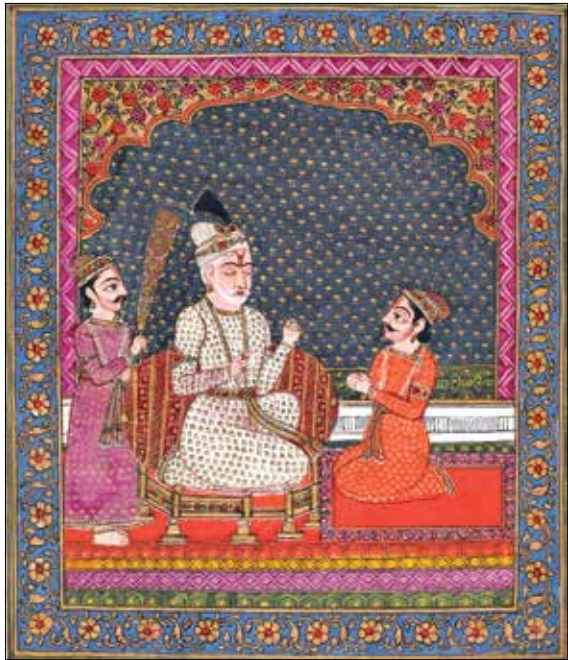
When Attachment Defeats Dharma

Dhritarashtra’s tragedy shows that knowledge of dharma is meaningless without the courage to confront wrongdoing, restrain those closest to power and act before injustice becomes irreversible

What is the use of knowing dharma if one does not have the courage to stand by it? Few figures in the Mahabharata remind us as powerfully as Dhritarashtra that the greatest failures of life do not always begin with ignorance. Sometimes, they begin with knowing what is right and still lacking the strength to act upon it. Dhritarashtra’s tragedy was not that he could not see with his eyes. His deeper tragedy was that, again and again, he failed to stand with the truth that his conscience already recognised. His life therefore becomes more than the story of a king. It becomes a mirror for every parent, corporate leader and citizen who must choose between attachment and duty, silence and justice, personal affection and dharma.

Dhritarashtra was born into the Kuru dynasty and, as the elder brother of Pandu, stood close to the centre of power in Hastinapur. Yet his physical blindness altered his destiny and shaped the way others viewed his claim to authority. This early wound is important to understand, because personal pain often becomes dangerous when it is not disciplined by wisdom. Dhritarashtra’s sense of deprivation did not remain only a private sorrow. Over time, it influenced his judgment, his relationship with his sons, and his inability to act with fairness towards the Pandavs. His life teaches us that hurt, if left unexamined, can slowly turn into insecurity, and insecurity can distort one’s understanding of justice.

When Pandu withdrew from the throne, Dhritarashtra came to rule Hastinapur. Yet even as he occupied the seat of power, he did not always possess the moral steadiness that power demands. He was not without intelligence, nor was he unaware of right and wrong. In fact, his tragedy becomes sharper because he often knew the truth. He recognised Duryodhan’s jealousy. He understood the bitterness growing within the royal household. He knew that the rivalry between the Kauravs and Pandavs could destroy Hastinapur. But knowledge without cour-



The greatest blindness is not the absence of sight, but the refusal to stand by the truth one already sees

age remained helpless. A person may understand dharma, speak of dharma and even respect dharma, but unless he is prepared to act for dharma, that understanding remains incomplete.

As a father, Dhritarashtra loved Duryodhan deeply. But love, when separated from moral responsibility, can become a force of ruin. A parent’s duty is not only to protect a child, but also to correct him when desire turns into arrogance and ambition turns into injustice. Dhritarashtra repeatedly saw the dangerous direction in which Duryodhan was moving, yet he chose indulgence over discipline. He mistook affection for protection and protection for silence. This is one of the most important life lessons from his story. True love does not hide a loved one from the consequences of wrongdoing. True love guides, restrains and corrects, even when correction is painful.

Dhritarashtra was also surrounded by wise counsel. Vidur spoke with clarity and courage. Bhishma represented experience and duty. Gandhari understood the moral danger of Duryodhan’s path. Krishna himself made every effort to prevent war when peace was still possible. Therefore, Dhri-

tarashtra cannot be seen as a man who lacked guidance. He lacked the will to follow guidance. This remains deeply relevant today. In families, organisations and public life, wise advice often exists. The real question is whether those in authority have the humility to listen and the courage to act. Wisdom has no power when authority chooses convenience over conscience.

The dice game reveals the depth of Dhritarashtra’s failure. He knew the tensions within the family. He understood Shakuni’s cunning. He could sense the danger of allowing resentment to enter the royal court in the form of a game. Yet he permitted events to unfold. When Draupadi was humiliated, the silence of the court became a moral wound in the history of Hastinapur. Dhritarashtra eventually intervened, but only after dignity had been attacked and injustice had already crossed its limit. His delayed action teaches us that justice must arrive when it is needed, not after the damage is done. Delayed justice can sometimes become another form of injustice.

This is why Dhritarashtra’s story cannot be limited to monarchy or ancient politics. It speaks

to every space where responsibility exists. Many families weaken because elders confuse peace with avoidance. Many institutions suffer because people in authority know what is wrong but do not want to confront those close to them. Many individuals remain silent because speaking the truth may disturb comfort, relationships or personal interest. Dhritarashtra’s weakness was not that he openly celebrated adharma. His weakness was that he allowed adharma to grow while hoping that somehow disaster could be avoided. But wrong does not disappear because we refuse to confront it. Often, it grows stronger in the silence of those who know better.

This lesson is equally relevant to corporate leadership. A corporate leader who cannot restrain injustice within his own circle, whether in a court, company or institution, cannot preserve justice in the larger world. Organisations often suffer not because those at the top do not understand the problem, but because they avoid confronting it. When favourites are protected, when uncomfortable advice is ignored, when toxic behaviour is tolerated because the person is useful, and when rules bend for those close to power, the culture of the organisation begins to weaken. Dhritarashtra’s story reminds us that authority loses credibility when it protects attachment over fairness.

A second corporate leadership lesson lies in the relationship between performance and ethics. In many organisations, short-term results can sometimes blind decision-makers to long-term damage. A high performer may be excused for arrogance, a powerful executive may be shielded despite repeated misconduct, or a profitable decision may be defended even when it weakens trust. But no organisation can remain strong if success is separated from character. Dhritarashtra’s attachment to Duryodhana shows what happens when capability, ambition or loyalty is allowed to override dharma. For corporate leaders, the message is clear: performance cannot be separated from ethics, and loyalty cannot be allowed to overpower fairness.

His life also teaches the value of impartiality. A ruler cannot behave only as a father. A person in authority cannot act only as the guardian of one side. Dhritarashtra’s duty was to protect justice in Hastinapur, not merely the interests of Duryodhan. The Pandavs too belonged to the same lineage. They too deserved fairness. But Dhritarashtra’s attachment clouded his judgment. This lesson applies far beyond the Mahabharata. In any position of responsibility, fairness must not depend on personal closeness. When affection overpowers justice, trust begins to collapse. When rules change according to relationships, institutions lose moral authority.

There is also a powerful moral lesson in Dhritarashtra’s regret. He was often anxious and conflicted. He listened to Vidur and felt disturbed. He heard Sanjay’s narration of the war and felt sorrow. He sensed that the Pandavs stood on stronger moral ground, yet remained tied to Duryodhan’s ambition. His sorrow, however, could not undo his earlier weakness. Regret after destruction is not the same as courage before destruction. Feeling bad after a wrong has taken place does not absolve us if we had the power to prevent it. Moral strength lies in acting before consequences become irreversible. Dhritarashtra’s story is tragic because he was not ignorant of dharma, yet he remained too bound by attachment to act upon it.

Dhritarashtra’s life gives us the answer to the question with which we began. Knowledge of dharma is not enough unless it is supported by courage, fairness and timely action. His tragedy was not that truth was hidden from him, but that he could not stand with the truth when it demanded sacrifice. He reminds us that love without fairness becomes weakness, power without courage becomes helplessness, and knowledge without action becomes guilt. The lesson of Dhritarashtra is therefore timeless: the greatest blindness is not the absence of sight, but the refusal to stand by the truth one already sees.

Views expressed are personal

The Forest That Changed a City

Beyond planting trees, Etawah’s Nagar Van has restored biodiversity, improved public health and created a replicable model for urban India; writes Arkraj Biswas

Etawah, a historic city in southwestern Uttar Pradesh, sits near where the Yamuna and Chambal rivers meet. It’s semi-arid, ravine-carved, and prone to sharp seasonal swings. Over 1.5 million people live here, and like most tier-II and tier-III cities across India, Etawah has been hit hard by rising concrete sprawl, urban heat, and falling water tables. Then something changed. A newly established Etawah Nagar Van under the Nagar Van Yojana (NVY), a national urban forestry scheme, came into the picture. The city saw a rapid green transformation. Here, you can find forest trees, cool air, a soft, pleasant smell, and the sound of birds returning. A degraded, abandoned piece of public land that was once common grazing land has now become a carbon sink, a genuine community space, and, surprisingly, a model for how to get climate finance right.

The visitor numbers alone prove it. Mornings bring 100 to 150 people, while evenings see 300 to 400 regular visitors, often rising to 500 to 600 on weekends. Children run to the swings and slides. Older people come for breathwork. The forest isn’t just a project anymore. It’s become something the city actually uses.

When people talk about green spaces, they count hectares and saplings. That misses a basic point. What actually matters is whether a place can heal you.

One morning, Sunil, an elderly man, told his story. A few months earlier, a serious illness had left him bedridden for nearly three months. He couldn’t leave the house. When the Nagar Van opened fully with its 5-kilometre walking path, shaded rest spots, and huts, he took his first steps back into the world here. “The air is different here,” he

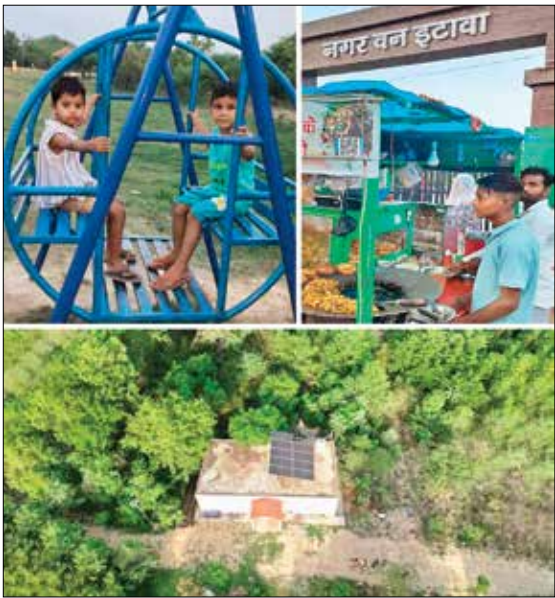
said, looking at the trees around him. “Cleaner. Full of birds. I got so much better. Just being here gave me my strength back.”

Now he comes every morning. He’s part of a group of older visitors who use the clean, fresh air for yoga, meditation, easy jogging, and the cute huts built as relaxing and resting spots. For them, the forest has become health infrastructure. And they’ve started asking for more. They have requested an open-air gym. That matters because it shows people aren’t just visiting; they’re treating it as part of their lives.

What separates Etawah from a standard park is its commitment to operating without adding carbon to the atmosphere. The District and Regional Forest Officers set one mandate: this place should be carbon-negative. This assessment is based on a Participatory Rural Appraisal (PRA) conducted during site monitoring, evaluating renewable power sources, 70% canopy cover, and three water-storage and groundwater-recharge infrastructure systems. The Van has been cut loose from the coal-heavy grid entirely. A decentralized solar micro-grid powers everything.

Lighting and safety. Evening visitors have always avoided large forests because of the fear of wildlife, snakes, and insect bites. Solar lights now line all the pathways. They have extended visiting hours well into the evening and created a genuinely safe space for women, children, and families. A four-person maintenance team, working in day and night shifts, keeps incidents at zero.

Water. Summers in Uttar Pradesh are brutal. Solar pumps draw water without a single litre of diesel or grid electricity. The water feeds into a solar-powered cooling system. Hundreds of walkers get free drinking water every day.



It’s not about being large or having special resources. It’s about choosing the right approach and sticking with it

The project’s success lies in integrating ecology, economics and community ownership rather than treating them as separate goals

Groundwater recharge. The district faces a serious groundwater crisis. Engineers built two water-harvesting ponds with a three-layer structure. The pond excavation uses three layers of materials with different permeability. Surface runoff slows down, urban sediment is filtered out, groundwater recharge accelerates, and the water table stabilizes.

Making Climate Finance Work Here’s what matters most for policymakers: how the money was managed. Under the Nagar Van Yojana (NVY), a scheme of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) administered through the National CAMPA

(Compensatory Afforestation Fund Management and Planning Authority), urban forest funding works out to ₹4 lakh per hectare. For Etawah’s 50 hectares, that amounted to ₹2 crore, released in two instalments. The first instalment of ₹1.40 crore was released by National CAMPA following procedural norms, ensuring financial accountability and progress verification.

The department treated the ₹2 crore strictly as foundational funding. It covered what mattered: planting and maintaining 2,20,000 trees (count verified by nursery plantation workers in March 2026), along with installing solar lights, a cooling system,

solar pumps, a water-harvesting system, toilets, and basic infrastructure for guards and maintenance staff. They chose native species like Neem, Peepal, and Banyan over exotic ornamentals. That decision paid off: more than 90% of the trees survived. Because these species belong here, maintenance costs also declined.

For visitor facilities, the site now has solar water coolers, walking paths, toilets, and parking space, while the forest department works closely with the municipality. They pooled their resources and made them work.

The future looks interesting too. Access is free now, so anyone can visit. But when we asked people what they’d be willing to pay, something interesting emerged: residents said they’d happily pay ₹10 to ₹20 as an entry fee. That voluntary, community-backed micro-transaction could cover the four-person maintenance team and daily operating costs. At the same time, it would shift the forest from a free public good to a modest paid-entry model, carrying the risk of excluding poorer residents who may depend on this low-cost health infrastructure the most.

A forest can’t run on its own. The backbone here is the Joint Forest Management (JFM) Committee, which brings the community into the management of the forest and includes representatives from local communities, elected bodies, and forest staff. This structure creates genuine local responsibility and ensures decisions on resource allocation and management priorities reflect community input rather than departmental control alone.

It has also created an economy outside the gates. Those 500-600 weekend visitors need food. By evening, vendor stalls line the

parking areas, selling sugarcane juice, snacks, and meals. Small businesses. Real livelihoods supported by the foot traffic the forest generates.

The Etawah Model as a Blueprint for Urban India

Big cities spend enormous sums on parks that depend on grid power and water to stay alive. Etawah took a different route.

A small city used CAMPA funding as intended. It chose native trees instead of exotics. It was built with a focus on reducing carbon emissions and increasing water recharge. An abandoned plot became a place people genuinely want to visit. What made it work was an engaged District Forest Officer committed to site-level decision-making, direct municipal collaboration on maintenance and facility management, a functional JFM Committee with genuine community participation, and sustained adherence to native-species restoration throughout the three-year establishment phase.

What’s worth noting is that it works because nothing here pulls in different directions. The ecological restoration depends on the same trees that lower maintenance costs. The trees that survive generate foot traffic for vendors. The management committee that runs the space consists of people from the local community. Money stays within the local system. It’s not a park designed somewhere else and installed here. It evolved.

Other cities could do this. It’s not about being large or having special resources. It’s about choosing the right approach and sticking with it.

The writer is a Research Associate at the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change. Views expressed are personal

ZAIDI HIGHLIGHTS IRAQ'S PAST CONFLICTS WITH IRAN

Trump welcomes new Iraqi PM Ali al-Zaidi to the White House

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump welcomed Iraq's new prime minister to the White House on Tuesday after strongly backing the political neophyte in his bid for office.

Ali al-Zaidi, a businessman with no political background, emerged as a consensus candidate in Iraq after months of deadlock over the premiership following last year's parliamentary elections.

When al-Zaidi was formally installed as prime minister-designate in April, Trump said in a social media post that it was the "beginning of a tremendous new chapter between our Nations — Prosperity, Stability, and Success like never seen before."



US President Donald Trump meets with Iraq's Prime Minister Ali al-Zaidi in the Oval Office of the White House on Tuesday AP/PTI

But Trump's interest and involvement in the next leadership in Iraq began long before that statement.

Iraq's dominant parliamentary bloc, the Coordination Framework, a coalition of Shiite parties allied with Iran,

Highlights

- » Al-Zaidi was formally installed as prime minister-designate in April
- » The issue of Iran is likely to loom large in the discussions on Tuesday
- » The Iraqi government has given non-state armed groups until the end of September to disarm

initially said it would back former Prime Minister Nouri al-Maliki, whom the Trump administration views as too close to Tehran.

The Republican president publicly announced his opposition to al-Maliki and threat-

ened to cut off aid to Iraq if he was appointed, adding that "if we are not there to help, Iraq has ZERO chance of Success, Prosperity, or Freedom."

The issue of Iran is likely to loom large in the discussions Tuesday. Iraq has been under pressure to disarm a network of Iran-backed militias operating in the country, some of which launched attacks on U.S. bases and diplomatic facilities after the U.S. and Israel launched their war against Iran in February.

Officially, the Iraqi government has given non-state armed groups until the end of September to disarm, but some of the most powerful militias have said they have no intention of doing so. AGENCIES

Israeli strike kills 9 in Gaza: Officials

CAIRO: An Israeli strike and gunfire killed at least nine Palestinians, including a 10-year-old boy, and a senior Hamas police officer, in the Gaza Strip on Tuesday, Gaza health and police officials said.

The deaths add to a toll of more than 1,100 Palestinians killed by Israeli attacks since an October ceasefire between Israel and Hamas took effect, according to health officials in the enclave.

The truce halted major fighting but has failed to stop sporadic violence. Four Israeli soldiers have been killed by militants in Gaza over the same period.

Medics said Muataz Abu Shaar, 10, was shot on Tuesday by Israeli gunfire in Rafah, southern Gaza.

In Jabalia, in the north of the enclave, an Israeli airstrike on a post of the Hamas-led police force killed at least seven people, including a woman, and wounded several other people, medics and police officials said.



Palestinians gather around a car hit in an Israeli military strike AP/PTI

Medics said Muataz Abu Shaar, 10, was shot by Israeli gunfire in Rafah, southern Gaza

The Hamas-led interior ministry said in a statement the dead included the head of the Jabalia police force, Colonel Mohammad

Marwan Salem, along with other officers.

Israel has stepped up its attacks against Hamas security men and police posts, killing dozens of them since October, according to police sources.

Israel wants Hamas to cede control of Gaza and disarm, and while the group said it was ready to relinquish power, it has always resisted calls to lay down arms. AGENCIES

Pak Army Chief meets Erdogan in Turkiye

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan Army Chief Field Marshal Asim Munir held high-level meetings in Turkiye, including one with President Recep Tayyip Erdogan, to promote "strategic partnership", the Army said on Tuesday.

The ISPR said in a statement that the field marshal, during his visit, met with the political and military leadership of Turkiye.

"Field Marshal Syed Asim Munir called on President HE Recep Tayyip Erdogan and Minister of National Defence, Yasar Guler, to discuss matters of mutual interest and regional security," as per Army. AGENCIES

Earthquake aid keeps flowing from Florida to Venezuela

Effort underscores stunning US-Venezuela dynamic shift

CARACAS: After her grandmother's house in Caracas narrowly survived last month's devastating back-to-back earthquakes, Alessandra Izaguirre was desperate to help Venezuela.

"Seeing my grandma and all these people affected made me feel like I had to do something, even if it was from the US," said the 18-year-old, who has spent the last couple weeks preparing food for volunteers at the Doral, Florida headquarters of the nonprofit Global Empowerment Mission.

Izaguirre is one of thousands of people who have participated in an exceptionally large grassroots humanitarian

'Whatever we can get to the Venezuelan public is what counts'

effort based at GEM, supported by donations from across the US and beyond and still going strong nearly three weeks after the catastrophe.

Hundreds of volunteers still show up each day at GEM's warehouses in Doral, where about half the population is of Venezuelan descent. They sort donated supplies — curated to address the latest needs — and prepare them for transport to

Caracas on daily flights. GEM's system, facilitated by the US State Department, has given members of the Venezuelan diaspora and others an outlet to support the ongoing crisis, and a trusted mechanism to send aid amid widespread concern about theft and corruption on the part of Venezuelan officials.

"Whatever we can get to the Venezuelan public is what counts," said Izaguirre.

The effort also underscores the stunning dynamic shift between the US and Venezuela since President Donald Trump ordered then-Venezuelan president Nicolas Maduro's capture in an early morning raid on Jan 3. AGENCIES

AS KYIV LOOKS TO BOOST ITS AIR DEFENCES

Ukraine downs 5 Russian ballistic missiles

KYIV: Ukraine's air force said Tuesday it intercepted five ballistic missiles launched by Russia in a raft of overnight attacks, although other missiles and drones got through and hit warehouses and a school in the capital of Kyiv.

It was the first time in almost two weeks that Ukraine said it had downed Russian ballistic missiles, which are harder to stop than drones or cruise missiles and have pummeled the country in Moscow's 4-year-old full-scale invasion.

Ukrainian air defences likely used the U.S.-made Patriot surface-to-air guided missile system, which is the most effective way of countering ballistic missiles, but ammunition for it has been in short supply amid the Iran



A sapper examines the impact site of a Russian missile in a residential area of Kyiv AP/PTI

war, despite European efforts to make up for the shortfall.

Along the cobblestoned Champs-Elysees in Paris, crowds cheered Ukrainian

troops marching in the annual Bastille Day parade, and President Volodymyr Zelenskyy received an ovation from European leaders who showed soli-

arity with Kyiv.

Ukrainian aviators trained in France flew aboard two Mirage 2000B fighter jets alongside French air force pilots.

Zelenskyy was in France seeking a remedy to his country's air defence problem, and he announced Monday that Ukraine is joining with nine other nations to form a coalition that will build a shared ballistic missile shield for Europe. Ukraine and its partners could jointly develop a mass-produced, low-cost system in the next 12 months, he said.

The Bastille Day parade featured about 500 troops from the coalition of the willing group of countries that have pledged to help with Ukraine's postwar security. AGENCIES

झारखण्ड सरकार
अधीक्षक का कार्यालय, शहीद निर्मल महतो मेडिकल कॉलेज अस्पताल, धनबाद।
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फ़ॉन : 1271 / SNMMCH दिनांक :- 14.07.2026

जेम ई-निविदा सूचना

शहीद निर्मल महतो चिकित्सा महाविद्यालय अस्पताल, धनबाद में वित्तीय वर्ष 2026-27 के लिए मानक स्तर के निमाताओं अथवा उनके अधिकृत एवं अनुमोदी वितरक से रक्त केन्द्र के उपयोग हेतु Refrigerated Centrifuge for General and Research Purpose के क्रय आपूर्ति एवं यथावश्यक अधिष्ठापन हेतु 2-बोली व्यवस्था (2-bid system) के तहत Gem Portal पर ONLINE निविदा आमंत्रित किया जाती है। जिसका Gem Bid No.- Gem/2026/B/7780179 है। ई-निविदा को www.Gem.gov.in पर देखी तथा ईस्ट्रुक् संवेदक द्वारा भाग ली जा सकती है। निविदा अपलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि- 04.08.2026 के अपराह्न 05:00 बजे तक होगी।

ह/—
अधीक्षक
शहीद निर्मल महतो मेडिकल कॉलेज अस्पताल धनबाद।

PR 384941 Health Med Edu and Family Welfare(26-27)D

मध्यप्रदेश मध्य क्षेत्र विद्युत वितरण कम्पनी लिमिटेड
कार्यालय महाप्रबंधक (सं/सं) वृत्त, रायसेन, पाटनदेव सागर रोड, रायसेन (म.प्र.)-464551
ई-मेल : raisencircle@gmail.com
क्र.महा.प्र.सं.सं./क्रय/2026-27/4196 रायसेन, दिनांक : 13.07.2026

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDERS

E-tender is invites from eligible bidders for following work.

Particulars	App. Value (In. Lakh)	Tender Fees (inclusive of GST @18% (In Rs.)	Bid Sub-mission Start & End Date	Bid Opening Date & Time
Empanelment of Agencies for new 33/11KV substation, additional/ Augmentation of PTR at existing 33/11 KV S/s, HT Lines, LT Lines, DTR, Service Line, meter related works and any other associated works as per SOR schedules in Raisen Circle of MPMKVVCL	1000/- Lakh	11800/-	15.07.2026 18:00 Hrs. up to 30.07.2026 15:00 Hrs.	31.07.2026 at 17:30 Hrs.

Other details, terms and conditions are available on company website : <https://portal.mpcz.in> & <https://mptenders.gov.in> or the under signed office.
M.P. Madhyam/126870/2026 GENERAL MANAGER (O&M)

KIND ATTENTION RAIL PASSENGERS! IMPORTANT INFORMATION

EXTENSION OF PERIODICITY OF SUMMER SPECIAL TRAINS

This is notified for the information of Rail Passengers that Railways have decided to extend the Periodicity of the run of following Summer Special Trains as under:-

Train No.	Station		Frequency/ Days of Run	Earlier Notified Upto	Extended Period		Trips
	From	To			From	To	
05193	Chhapra	Pathankot	Weekly (Mon)	13.07.2026	20.07.2026	28.09.2026	11
05194	Pathankot	Chhapra	Weekly (Wed)	15.07.2026	22.07.2026	30.09.2026	11
09611	Ajmer Jn.	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	Weekly (Wed)	15.07.2026	22.07.2026	30.09.2026	11
09612	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	Ajmer Jn.	Weekly (Thursday)	16.07.2026	23.07.2026	01.10.2026	11
04731	Shri Ganganagar	Samastipur Jn.	Weekly (Sunday)	28.06.2026	26.07.2026		01
04732	Samastipur Jn.	Shri Ganganagar	Weekly (Tuesday)	30.06.2026	28.07.2026		01

Note: Rest of instructions will hold good.
For any other information passengers are requested to contact RailMadad Helpline No. 139 or may visit Indian Railways website <https://enquiry.indianrail.gov.in> or NTES App.

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Philippine police probe killing of American marine biologist

MANILA: An American marine biologist was shot and killed by three men who barged into his house in the central Philippines over the weekend, and efforts were underway to apprehend the suspects, police said Tuesday.

Police said Kent Carpenter, 73, was with his Filipina companion in a house in the coastal town of Sibulan in Negros Oriental province on Sunday night when three men, forced their way in.

One drew a gun and shot Carpenter in the head, police said his companion told them. The men took a laptop, an unspecified amount of cash and a backpack before fleeing, national police spokesperson Col. Allen Rae Co told reporters.

Regional police spokesperson Lt. Col. Joem Malong told The AP that Carpenter's companion sustained unspecified injuries and was being treated. AGENCIES

Lebanon, Israel hold US-brokered talks in Rome to implement framework deal

Both countries have long history of failed ceasefires

BEIRUT/ROME: Lebanon and Israel resumed talks on Tuesday in the Italian capital, with Beirut hoping for progress towards securing an Israeli withdrawal from south Lebanon under a U.S.-brokered deal, although expectations for swift progress were low.

U.S.-led diplomacy has emerged since Hezbollah and Israel returned to war on March 2 amid the wider regional conflict, moving forward despite strong objections from the Iran-backed group, which believes only Iranian pressure on Washington can secure an end to the war and Israeli withdrawal.

Iran demanded an end to the war in Lebanon as part of its interim deal with Washington signed last month, but the agreement has been shaken over the last week by renewed U.S.-Iranian hostilities in the Gulf. Israel's military is occupying what it describes as a "buffer zone" about 10 km (6 miles) into Lebanon along the entire length of the Israeli border. Israeli officials say the zone

Takeaways

- » The 1949 Lebanese-Israeli General Armistice Agreement ended hostilities following the 1948 Arab-Israeli war
- » That relative stability began to unravel in the 1970s as the Palestine Liberation Organisation expanded its armed presence in Lebanon

THE TALKS, SET TO LAST TWO DAYS AT US EMBASSY IN ROME

is necessary to protect northern Israeli communities from attacks launched by Hezbollah.

A meeting in Washington on June 26 produced an agreement that called for an end to the Lebanon conflict, the disarmament of militant groups - an apparent reference to Hezbollah - as well as the deployment of Lebanese troops to the south and the progressive withdrawal of Israeli forces.

But deadly Israeli strikes have continued and Hezbollah has rejected the agreement as well as efforts to disarm it.

Israel, meanwhile, has said its troops would remain in southern Lebanon as long as Hezbollah

remained armed.

The talks, set to last two days at the U.S. embassy in Rome, will aim to set out how to implement the framework deal, Lebanese officials told Reuters. One of the officials said moving the talks to Italy would make it easier for both countries' delegations to consult their governments for guidance as they negotiate.

Lebanon and Israel have never normalised relations, but they do have a precedent for an agreement that successfully contained conflict. The 1949 UN-brokered Lebanese-Israeli General Armistice Agreement ended hostilities following the 1948 Arab-Israeli war. With sustained international backing and UN monitoring, it established the de facto border that largely remains in place today and prevented a return to full-scale war for roughly two decades. That relative stability began to unravel in the 1970s as the Palestine Liberation Organisation expanded its armed presence in Lebanon, provoking repeated clashes with Israel that culminated in Israel's invasions of Lebanon in 1978 and 1982.

Since Israel's 1982 full-scale invasion of Lebanon, agreements and ceasefires intended to end hostilities have repeatedly broken down. Parties have exploited lulls in fighting to buy time, rebuild capabilities and consolidate political or territorial gains ahead of the next round of conflict. AGENCIES

'Majority of new Ebola cases from unknown chains of transmission'

BUINA: The Ebola outbreak in eastern Congo "continues to outpace the response efforts," the World Health Organisation's emergencies chief said on Tuesday after returning from a trip to Bunia, in Ituri province, which is one of the worst hit areas.

"Perhaps the most alarming finding is that many of the newly reported deaths are people who died in their communities without ever reaching a health facility and without

“CONGO HAS BEEN BATTLING THE VIRUS SINCE MAY, WITH NO APPROVED TREATMENT”

receiving care," Chikwe Ihekweazu said.

"And as of today, 80 per cent of new cases are outside our contact lists and so are coming to us from unknown

chains of transmission."

Congo has been battling the outbreak of a rare type of Ebola since May, with no approved treatment or vaccine. The Africa Centre for Disease Control said last week that it is the fastest-growing Ebola outbreak on the continent.

As of Monday, at least 1,926 people have been infected, and 702 have died in three provinces in Congo from the rare Bundibugyo virus, Congolese authorities said. AGENCIES

NO DEATHS SO FAR

Hundreds evacuated from Fontainebleau fires near Paris



Water bomber drops water while fighting wildfires in the Fontainebleau forest region of Paris on Monday AP/PTI

NOISY-SUR-ECOLE: Hundreds of firefighters battled two blazes on Tuesday in the Fontainebleau forest south of Paris that have consumed nearly 2,000 hectares (about 4,900 acres) and forced the evacuation of 1,000 people, local authorities said.

Bigger fires have been ravaging areas of southern France, but the Fontainebleau fire is exceptionally close to the densely populated region surrounding the French capital.

Water-dumping planes repeatedly dived into the Seine River to scoop up water and douse the fires — the first time such aircraft had ever been used to fight fires in the Paris region, the regional fire chief said. Smoke blanketed the treetops and hung in the air on

Smoke blanketed the treetops and hung in the air on Tuesday as authorities sought to get fires under control

Tuesday as authorities sought to get the fires under control.

No deaths or injuries have been reported.

Two people have been arrested in connection with the Fontainebleau fires, and two others arrested for fires elsewhere in France, Interior Minister Laurent Nunez said Tuesday on BFM television. AGENCIES

WPI inflation rises to 9.87% in June; price of minerals, food items spike

The latest WPI inflation data is based on the 2022-23 base year

OUR CORRESPONDENT

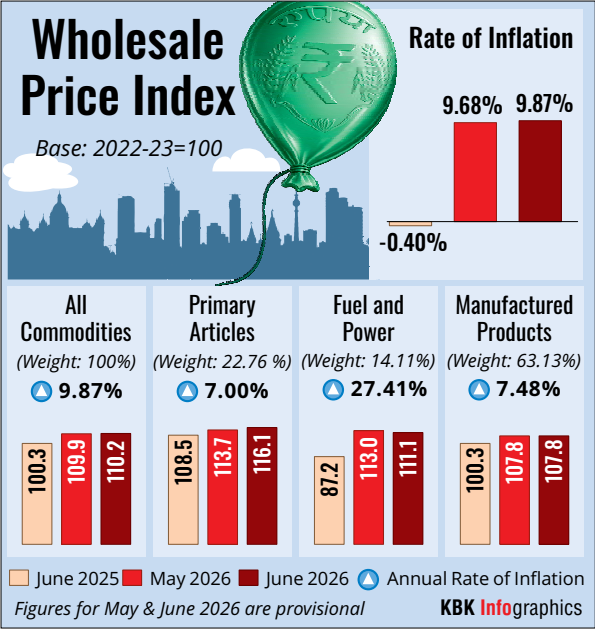
NEW DELHI: Wholesale price inflation rose to 9.87 per cent in June, from 9.68 per cent in May, led by a sharp spike in prices of non-food and food products. The latest wholesale price index (WPI) inflation data is based on the 2022-23 base year. As per the data, food inflation rose to 5.49 per cent in June, from 3.60 per cent in May, as food prices rose during the month following a rain-fall deficit due to the El Niño impact.

Non-food articles WPI inflation was also higher at 11.07 per cent, while in minerals it was 9.45 per cent in June.

“Mineral Oils (containing Petroleum Products), Food Articles, Manufacture of Basic Metals, and Manufacture of Chemicals and Chemical Products have been major drivers of WPI inflation in June 2026,” the Commerce and Industry Ministry said.

WPI inflation in fuel and power was down to 27.41 per cent in June, from a peak of 30.33 per cent in May. In manufactured products, inflation was unchanged at 7.48 per cent as in May.

Barclays, in a note, said global commodity prices and crude oil prices had taken a



‘Mineral Oils, Food Articles, Manufacture of Basic Metals, and Manufacture of Chemicals & Chemical Products have been major drivers of WPI inflation in June’

breather in June with the truce announcement between the US and Iran. This was reflected in lower fuel and power WPI inflation.

“But with the peace deal again coming under threat with the re-escalation of tensions in

the Middle East, we are watchful of incoming WPI and PPI prints. In our view, these inflation prints are closer to peak, and we expect softening over the next few months,” Barclays said.

India Ratings and Research

HIGHLIGHTS

» WPI inflation in fuel and power was down to 27.41 per cent in June, from a peak of 30.33 per cent in May

» In manufactured products, inflation was unchanged at 7.48 per cent as in May

» As per the data, food inflation rose to 5.49% in June, from 3.60% in May, as food prices rose during the month following a rain deficit due to El Niño impact

» Barclays said, global commodity prices & crude oil prices had taken a breather in June with truce announcement between the US & Iran. This was reflected in lower fuel and power WPI inflation

broad-base effect with prices across groups – primary articles, fuel and power and manufactured products likely to rise. This is expected due to El Nino impact on food prices, though some ease could be recorded in July. Resurgence in crude prices due to fresh escalation in the West Asia conflict would be another contributing factor,” Arora said.

BofA Global Research, Head of India and ASEAN Economic Research, Rahul Bajoria said WPI is expected to cool off in the third quarter of 2026.

This is the second monthly reading for WPI and the output Producer Price Index (PPI) on the revised 2022-23 base. The government had last month said that it would simultaneously release WPI and PPI every month, and WPI would be fully replaced by PPI over a five-year period.

The output PPI - set to replace the WPI - moved in line with wholesale prices at 9.6 per cent YoY, against 9.4 per cent in May 2026. The rise was mainly driven by higher agricultural inflation.

Retail or consumer price index-based inflation too had surged to a 17-month high of 4.38 per cent in June, as against 3.93 per cent in the previous month, data released on Monday showed.

India launches services output index with 2024-25 as base year

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India on Tuesday launched a new monthly indicator to track activity in its services economy, with the first trial release showing broad-based expansion across key sectors and double-digit growth in 14 of 19 sub-sectors in April 2026.

The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) released the first sub-sectoral Index of Services Production (ISP), aimed at providing a more timely measure of activity in the formal services sector, which accounts for more than half of India’s economic output.

The trial index, based on the 2024-25 base year, covers about 60 per cent of the services sector and tracks monthly movements across areas, including trade, transport, telecommunications, banking, IT services, real estate and hospitality.

The ministry said the index will be published on the 29th of every month, while an overall services production index will be introduced later after assessing the stability of the trial series and expanding coverage.

Wholesale trade, retail, accommodation and food, road transport, air transport, telecommunications, and banking are among the sub-sectors, covering about 60 per cent of the services sector. Fourteen of the 19 sub-sectors posted double-digit year-on-year growth in April, with accommodation and food services leading the expansion at

Air transport declined by 13.9 per cent, and railway transport was down by 0.4 per cent in April

37.2 per cent, followed by retail trade at 30.8 per cent, administrative and support services at 28.7 per cent and real estate at 27.7 per cent.

Only railway and air transport posted a decline in April, according to the trial ISP.

“The ISP (Index of Services Production) represents an important milestone in strengthening India’s statistical system and improving the measurement of the services sector, which accounts for more than half of the country’s economic activity,” MoSPI said in a statement.

Air transport declined by 13.9 per cent, and railway transport was down by 0.4 per cent in April. Top sub-sectors reporting strong growth in April were ‘accommodation and food’ (37.2 per cent), retail trade (30.8 per cent), administrative and support services (28.7 per cent) and real estate (27.7 per cent), according to the index.

MoSPI said the release of sub-sectoral ISPs will provide, for the first time, a monthly measure of short-term movements in India’s formal services sector, with a coverage of about 60 per cent.

“Based on its data sources,

namely, GST and Administrative Data, ISP would cover the formal sector enterprises only.

“Accordingly, services which are not covered in ISP are those which are either related to core government activities or are dominated by non-market activities and the informal sector,” the ministry said. Subsequent ISPs will be released on the 29th of every month.

Briefing media on the trial ISP release, Chief Economic Adviser V Anantha Nageswaran said there is work ahead...the index measures volumes, but the data arrives as values. So, everything depends on how we adjust for prices.

“Building price indices for services is, of course, not an easy task, as it is the case for goods in general, and that is the most valuable investment we can make, and we will continue to make in producing this index of services production,” he said.

Coverage will widen, with inclusion of health services, education, and own dwelling businesses sub-sectors that increase coverage to 85 to 90 per cent of the formal services sector activity in the economy.

Dalip Singh, Additional General, MoSPI, said the work is in progress to compile ISP of the sub-sectors, like ‘health and residential care’, education and ownership of dwelling based on administrative data to ensure coverage of more than 80 per cent of the services activities of the economy.

He also said the April data reflects the impact of the West Asia conflict.

Rupee falls 48 paise to 96.16 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee depreciated 48 paise to close at 96.16 against the US dollar on Tuesday, amid a surge in crude oil prices and renewed geopolitical concerns.

Forex traders said the rupee came under pressure due to a combination of factors — crude oil prices climbed on renewed geopolitical tensions, while demand for the US dollar increased as investors moved toward safe-haven assets.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.95 and settled for the day at 96.16, down 48 paise from its previous closing.

On Monday, the rupee depreciated 30 paise to close at 95.68 against the US dollar.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 101.07, down 0.16 per cent.

“When uncertainty rises, and interest rates are expected to stay higher for longer, the dollar often becomes the market’s preferred shelter, putting pressure on emerging market currencies like the rupee,” CR Forex Advisors MD Amit Pabari said.

An expensive crude oil import bill widens the trade gap because India, which imports over 85 per cent of its crude, must purchase it in US dollars, driving a massive foreign exchange outflow. This surge in dollar demand weakens the domestic currency against the US dollar, traders said. PFI

Direct taxes grow 16% to ₹6.51 lakh cr so far

NEW DELHI: The net direct tax collection grew 16.40 per cent to over Rs 6.51 lakh crore till July 13 this fiscal, driven by higher corporate tax mop-up, government data showed on Tuesday.

The net corporate tax collection rose 22 per cent to Rs 2.40 lakh crore, and mop-up from net non-corporate tax (NCT), which includes taxes paid by individuals, HUFs, and firms, grew about 12 per cent to over Rs 3.84 lakh crore till July 13. Securities Transaction Tax (STT) grew 48 per cent to Rs 26,429 crore.

Refunds worth Rs 1.22 lakh crore were issued during the period, up 14.57 per cent over the year-ago period.

On a gross basis, direct tax collection increased 16.11 per cent to over Rs 7.73 lakh crore.



This includes corporate tax mop-up of over Rs 3.35 lakh crore and NCT of about Rs 4.12 lakh crore.

The government has budgeted to collect Rs 26.97 lakh crore from direct taxes in the current fiscal year, a 15 per cent growth over Rs 23.40 lakh crore collected in FY26.

Deloitte India Partner Rohinton Sidhwa said the direct tax numbers seem to indicate that corporate earnings do not seem to have been hit by the war or a slowdown, and profits seem to be largely insulated. PFI

Sensex tanks 561 pts on sharp surge in crude prices due to renewed flare-up in West Asia

MUMBAI: Stock market benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty tumbled on Tuesday as a sharp surge in crude oil prices due to the renewed flare-up in West Asia dented investors’ sentiment.

After three days of gains, the 30-share BSE Sensex dropped 561.46 points, or 0.72 per cent, to settle at 77,054.94. During the day, it tumbled 614.92 points, or 0.79 per cent, to 77,001.48.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 158.95 points, or 0.66 per cent, to end at 24,052.05.

Fresh foreign fund outflows and the rupee falling below 96 mark against the US dollar also hit the sentiment, analysts said.

From the Sensex pack, HCL Tech declined the most by 4.42 per cent. Bajaj Finserv, Inter-Globe Aviation, State Bank of



India, Mahindra & Mahindra, and Larsen & Toubro were also among the major laggards.

Bharti Airtel, Tata Consultancy Services, Sun Pharma, Tata Steel, Adani Ports and Eternal were the winners. Brent crude, the global oil

benchmark, surged 4.26 per cent to \$86.85 per barrel..

Broader markets also closed lower as the BSE MidCap Select index tumbled 1.01 per cent and SmallCap Select index declined 0.55 per cent. Among sectors, BSE MidS-

BRAND VALUE SURGES 55%

JSW Group recognised as India’s fastest-growing conglomerate

MUMBAI: JSW Group, one of India’s leading diversified conglomerates, has been recognised as India’s fastest-growing conglomerate brand in the Brand Finance India 100 2026 report, with its brand value rising 55 per cent year-on-year to \$2.3 billion.

The ranking, published by Brand Finance, the world’s leading brand valuation consultancy, reflects the Group’s continued strengthening of its market position through capacity expansion, value-added products and sustainability-focused investments. The recognition comes in



a year when India’s branded economy demonstrated notable resilience.

According to the Brand Finance India 100 2026 report, the collective brand value of India’s top 100 brands reached a record \$252.8 billion, an increase of 7 per cent year-on-year, driven by con-

tinued investments in digital transformation, infrastructure, manufacturing, financial inclusion and innovation across key sectors.

Against this backdrop, JSW Group’s 55 per cent growth stands out as the fastest among the country’s conglomerate brands.

Brand value is understood as the net economic benefit that a brand owner would achieve by licensing the brand in the open market, while brand strength measures the efficacy of a brand’s performance on intangible measures relative to its competitors. MPOST

‘PSPCL meets record 17,328 MW demand without power cuts’

PATIALA: The Punjab Government, led by Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann, is ensuring uninterrupted power supply to consumers across the state while successfully meeting record electricity demand without imposing any power cuts.

Power Minister S. Tarunpreet Singh Sondh said that Punjab State Power Corporation Limited (PSPCL) successfully met a record power demand of 17,328 MW on Tuesday without any power cuts.

He said that the State Government had assured farmers of eight hours of uninterrupted power supply for agricultural purposes.

However, farmers are presently receiving more than eight hours of supply. He added that, for the first time during the paddy season, farmers had to switch off their tubewells because of the availability of surplus power.

S. Sondh said that the State Government remains committed to fulfilling the promises made to the people of Punjab. He also directed PSPCL officers to ensure uninterrupted power supply to farmers so that agricultural operations continue smoothly without any difficulty.

Farmers Receiving 12 Hours of Uninterrupted Power Supply Against the Assured 8 Hours, CMD Dr. Basant Garg said. MPOST

India-UK CETA comes into force today: Key benefits, tariff cuts and sectors impacted

This will be the 6th FTA to be implemented by the Modi government. Earlier, India implemented such pacts with Mauritius, UAE, Australia, EFTA & Oman

NEW DELHI: The India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), signed on July 25, 2025 after years of negotiations, comes into force on July 15, 2026, becoming the sixth free trade agreement implemented by the Narendra Modi government.

India has previously implemented FTAs with Mauritius, the UAE, Australia, the European Free Trade Association & Oman. CETA is among India’s biggest trade pacts in recent years and will provide duty-free access for nearly 99% of Indian exports to the UK.

ADVANTAGE INDIA:

Labour-intensive sectors including garments, textiles, footwear, carpets, processed food, cereals, fruits, vegetables, spices, fish and meat products will enjoy zero-duty access to the UK, replacing existing duties of 4-16%.

The agreement also benefits automobiles and auto components, machinery, electronics, fabricated metal products, ceramics, glass, stone and cement products. Indian consumers could benefit from lower prices of imported British products such as salmon, lamb, machinery, electronics, chocolates, soft drinks, cosmet-

ics, soaps, perfumes, shaving creams and nail polish due to tariff reductions. India will also reduce tariffs on silver, its largest import from the UK, to zero over 10 years.

AUTO SECTOR:

For the first time under an FTA, India will significantly cut import duties on fully built UK cars & trucks, with tariffs on cars falling from 110% to 10% in phases. Petrol & diesel vehicles will receive concessions immediately, while EV, hybrid and hydrogen passenger vehicles will become eligible from the sixth year.

India will allow imports of

CLOSER LOOK

- » Labour-intensive sectors will enjoy zero-duty access to the UK, replacing existing duties of 4-16%
- » India will cut import duties on fully built UK cars & trucks to 10% and 8.8% respectively in phases
- » India has excluded products such as fresh apples, walnuts, whey, blue-veined cheese, certain seeds, gold bars and smartphones from tariff concessions

3.78 lakh conventional-engine passenger vehicles from the UK at concessional duty over the first 15 years. Tariffs on UK-made trucks will decline from 44% to 8.8% within quota by the fifth year. Meanwhile, Indian

electric, hybrid and hydrogen passenger vehicles exported within an annual quota will enter the UK duty-free.

ALCOHOL:

India will gradually lower tariffs on premium alcoholic

beverages including Scotch whisky, bourbon, rum, gin, vodka, tequila and brandy.

The current 150% duty will decline to 110% in the first year and 75% by the tenth year for qualifying products, subject to minimum import prices. On Scotch whisky, the tariff will eventually fall to 40%.

NO CONCESSIONS:

India has excluded products such as fresh apples, walnuts, whey, blue-veined cheese, certain seeds, gold bars and smartphones from tariff concessions.

The UK has similarly excluded several meat products, egg-based items, rice and sugar.

GOVERNMENT PROCUREMENT:

India has opened about 40,000 high-value central government procurement contracts in sectors including transport, infrastructure and green energy to eligible UK suppliers.

INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY RIGHTS:

According to GTRI, India retained key safeguards by resisting patent-term extensions and pharmaceutical data exclusivity. The agreement also preserves India’s right to use compulsory licensing for accessing critical medicines

during emergencies.

DOUBLE CONTRIBUTION CONVENTION:

Indian companies operating in the UK will be exempt from making social security contributions for employees deputed there for up to five years, benefiting IT firms such as TCS and Infosys.

RULES OF ORIGIN:

The agreement prescribes rules to ensure only goods substantially produced or value-added in India or the UK qualify for preferential tariffs, preventing third-country products from misusing FTA benefits. AGENCIES

A rivalry forged in bad blood

Messi, Bellingham and history collide in Argentina-England semi-final

KANSAS CITY: A World Cup semi-final between Argentina and England scarcely needs extra storylines, but Wednesday's clash in Atlanta arrives carrying decades of soccer drama, political baggage and two teams who have made a habit of surviving on the edge.

From England's victory at the 1966 World Cup to the shadow cast by the 1982 Falklands War, from Diego Maradona's "Hand of God" goal in 1986 to major duels in 1998 and 2002, meetings between the countries have long felt larger than soccer.

Yet Argentina's players and coach Lionel Scaloni have sought to strip away the emotion surrounding the rivalry, insisting the semi-final should be treated as another step toward the biggest prize in the sport.

"We have to experience it for what it is: a World Cup semi-final against a powerhouse, a great team, and try to arrive in the best possible condition to compete again," Lionel Messi said.

The reigning champions have reached the last four struggling far more than expected. They beat Cape Verde 3-2 after extra time, staged a remarkable comeback from 2-0 down with 11 minutes remaining to defeat



This will be Lionel Messi's first match against England; RIGHT: Harry Kane will look to be among goals again



Egypt 3-2, and then overcame Switzerland 3-1 in extra time.

The 39-year-old Messi acknowledged the physical toll of the tournament after a succession of draining knockout victories.

England's route has been no less taxing. Thomas Tuchel's side survived with 10 men to beat Mexico in brutal conditions in Mexico City in the round of 16 before edging Norway 2-1 after extra time in a hot and humid Miami on Saturday.

If Argentina have repeatedly found a way through

17

Argentina have slammed in 17 goals at the 2026 World Cup, the most of any team

adversity, England have done the same through resilience,

grit and the emergence of Jude Bellingham as the face of their campaign.

The 23-year-old Real Madrid midfielder scored twice against Mexico and twice more against Norway, further cementing his status as the team's indispensable player.

Harry Kane remains captain and focal point in attack, but increasingly this feels like Bellingham's tournament.

Tuchel, however, knows individual brilliance may not be enough. The England manager has openly voiced frustra-

tion with aspects of his team's performances, arguing they can play with greater precision and control.

Argentina's hopes once again rest heavily on Messi, who has scored eight goals in the tournament, level with France's Kylian Mbappe in the race for the Golden Boot.

Remarkably, Wednesday will mark Messi's first career appearance against England, adding another chapter to a fixture that has long captured the imagination of both nations.

Former Argentina striker Carlos Tevez, who played for Manchester City and Manchester United, believes the weight of history still lingers.

"They are surely waiting for revenge for what Diego did in 1986. They are thinking about that, they have a love-hate relationship with Diego because of that match. History is there, history is alive," he said on ESPN Argentina.

The South Americans, despite facing a seemingly more favourable path to the semi-finals, struggled repeatedly against opponents they were expected to beat.

Switzerland, ranked 19th in the world, were the highest-ranked side they have faced, yet Scaloni's men were pushed to their limits.

NEW YORK: A new refereeing protocol has added to the powder keg of public perception over fairness at the World Cup, a former FIFA referee said on Monday, with another refereeing controversy involving Argentina adding fuel to fan complaints.

The holders' passage to Wednesday's semi-final against England has been accompanied by repeated complaints from opponents over refereeing decisions, amid social media speculation the tournament has favoured Lionel Messi's side.

The saga came to a head on Saturday in Argentina's quarter-final defeat of Switzerland, as Breel Embolo was sent off for a second yellow card for simulation, a VAR rule that Swiss coach Murat Yakin called "unacceptable." The protocol over mistaken identity is one of several incidents in which VAR is allowed to intervene under rules applied to the 2026-27 season and the World Cup, putting a largely untested protocol up for public debate.

"I don't think it should have been applied in the first place. It was too broad," said Christina Unkel, British broadcaster ITV's rules analyst for the World Cup and a former FIFA referee.

That the protocol benefited Argentina - who social media critics have dubbed "VARgen-



Axar, Gill shine as India break UK tour duck

LONDON: Tons of patience mixed with the right amount of aggression was the key to Indian women's cricket team's epic Test win over England, said chief coach Amol Muzumdar as he lauded centurion Yastika Bhatia for her "special knock" and pacer Kranti Gaud for her "controlled line and length."

Gaud's seven-wicket match haul and Bhatia's hundred played a big role in India's historic 270-run win over England in what was the first ever women's Test played on the hallowed turf of Lord's.

"Yeah, you can say that (it was a perfect game). We bat-



Shubman Gill made 80 off 75 before retiring hurt

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ter, it was a good game for us," Muzumdar said during the press-conference.

"I wouldn't be able to pinpoint one particular thing ... I think we were disciplined in our approach towards our batting. And disciplined in our bowling as well, sticking to the basics of cricket. While bowling, as I said, good line and length, controlled line and length. Aggression mixed with patience. So I think that was a key factor for this win."

Bhatia's 113 off 158 in the second innings helped India set England a mammoth 457-run target.

MUZUMDAR HAILS EPIC TEST WIN

India mixed aggression & patience at Lord's

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India's Sneha Rana was the pick of the bowlers for India

"Yeah, you can say that (it was a perfect game). We battled well, we bowled extremely

well and we fielded even better, it was a good game for us," Muzumdar said during the

press-conference.

"I wouldn't be able to pinpoint one particular thing ... I think we were disciplined in our approach towards our bowling. And disciplined in our bowling as well, sticking to the basics of cricket. While bowling, as I said, good line and length, controlled line and length. Aggression mixed with patience. So I think that was a key factor for this win."

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Leisure



'IF I KEEP REPEATING MYSELF, I'LL GET BORED'

Huma Qureshi explained why layered characters matter to her

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Huma Qureshi's scene with Nawazuddin Siddiqui in 'Gangs of Wasseypur' Part 2, where they speak about consent, has become a pop culture moment. From making a memorable debut to taking on a string of unconventional roles in films like 'Ek Thi Daayan', 'D-Day', 'Dedh Ishqiya', 'Badlapur', 'Monica', 'O My Darling', the acclaimed series 'Maharani' and now 'Baby Do Die Do', the New Delhi-born actor has carved a distinctive path in Bollywood.

Instead of chasing glamorous roles, Huma has often chosen layered characters that challenge patriarchal stereotypes. Her latest film, 'Baby Do Die Do', is another example. She plays Baby, a deaf and mute contract killer who carries out murders using a red umbrella. The film is produced by Huma and her brother, actor Saqib Saleem. Through their production house, the sibling duo wants to back projects they believe are unconventional, entertaining and unique. The siblings were recently in Kolkata to promote the film and interact with audiences.

Huma admitted that Baby is 'a weird character' but said that is exactly what attracted her to the role. "Throughout my career, I have chosen filmmakers and scripts that are not one-dimensional. I am very grateful to be part of a film like 'Baby Do Die Do'. It's mainstream, fun, accessible and still unique," she said.

She added that playing a deaf and mute character needed a lot of preparation. "More than not being able to speak, not being able to hear was the tougher part. We had professionals on set who helped us," she said.

Talking about her choice of films, Huma said she likes exploring different kinds of roles. "If I keep repeating myself as an actor, I will get bored."



Saqib Saleem & Huma Qureshi

WEAVE THE FUTURE 4.0

India's journey towards sustainable & circular textiles

The exhibition, at Dilli Haat, INA, New Delhi, will remain open till July 17, 2026

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Union Minister of Textiles Giriraj Singh visited 'Weave the Future 4.0' at Dilli Haat, INA, New Delhi on July 13. Others who visited alongside included Neelam Shami Rao, Secretary, Ministry of Textiles; Dr M Beena, Development Commissioner (Handloom); Amrit Raj, Development Commissioner (Handicraft); Thomas McClenaghan, Minister Counsellor & Head of Sustainable Modernisation, European Union and other senior representatives of the Ministry of Textiles, Government of India.

Speaking at the exhibition, Giriraj Singh said, "As textile consumption continues to rise, it is imperative that we strengthen circular economy practices, promote responsible production and scale innovative solutions that transform textile waste into valuable resources. Initiatives such as 'Weave the Future 4.0' demonstrate how entrepreneurship, innovation and sustainability can converge to create both economic opportunities and environmental impact. Equally important is ensuring that the millions of workers who form the backbone of this sector benefit from dignified livelihoods and improved incomes. India is committed to positioning itself as a global leader in sustainable textiles, contributing not only to the nation's growth but also to the world's transition towards a more responsible and resilient textile ecosystem."

An initiative of 'DC Handlooms', Ministry of Textiles, Government of India, 'Weave the Future 4.0: Upcycling Edition' is the fourth edition of



the platform, focusing on the relationship between materials, communities and the environment. The exhibition explores how traditional knowledge, responsible resource use and innovative practices can come together to create sustainable solutions for everyday living.

Scheduled till July 17, 2026, at Dilli Haat, New Delhi, the six-day exhibition brings together more than 100 brands, makers, artisans, recyclers, thrift collectives and innovators from across India. It shows a wide range of approaches including upcycling, recycling, repair, repurposing and circular design, highlighting how materials can be transformed through creativity and conscious practices.

Dr M Beena, Development

Commissioner (Handlooms), Ministry of Textiles, Government of India, said, "'Weave the Future' has evolved into a national platform that connects India's handloom and craft heritage with innovation-led solutions for textile waste management. This edition brings together artisans, students, startups, designers and recycling enterprises to explore collaborative approaches towards addressing the growing challenge of textile waste through upcycling, repair, recycling and circular design practices that we Indians have followed through generations. The strong participation of young entrepreneurs in 'Weave the Future 4.0' reflects the growing interest in sustainable consumption and resource efficiency. It also highlights the importance of creating platforms that encourage practical and scalable solutions while generating livelihood and entrepreneurship opportunities across the value chain."

Visitors at 'Weave the Future 4.0' can experience a diverse range of activities and exhibits, including:

- ❖ Upcycled and recycled products developed by artisans, designers, brands and

- innovators
- ❖ Interactive installations exploring textile waste, material recovery and circularity
- ❖ Repair, reuse and recycling demonstrations
- ❖ Workshops and knowledge-sharing sessions on sustainable design and craft-led innovation
- ❖ Conversations around circular fashion, conscious consumption and regenerative futures

As part of 'Weave the Future 4.0', the 'Marammat' workshop was organised on July 13 and will be held again on July 17 in collaboration with 'Rafuoghar'. This hands-on workshop uses fabric to explore ideas of rupture, repair and resilience. Through processes such as cutting, stitching, mending and layering, participants engage with cloth as a medium for personal expression, reflection and transformation. Embracing irregular threads, raw edges and visible repairs, the workshop encourages slowing down, caring and reconnecting - with materials, surroundings and oneself - promoting repair as a process of renewal rather than imperfection.